

Improv activity notes

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Rituals

Practices that establish focus, trust, and the working container.

Jesse's Opening Meditation

RITUAL

Purpose: Transition students from ordinary life into class readiness; Ground students in breath, body, and presence.

PLAYERS Whole class	TIME 5-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Low
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Skills: presence / risk agreement / anti-judgment / class container

How it works

1. Breathe deeply from the belly - Jesse frames this as breathing from where *chi* lives. Eyes closed.
2. Notice what appears in the darkness - floaters, light, images, whatever arises.
3. Imagine a grounding cord running from the spine down to the center of the earth.
4. Body scan: toes to feet to ankles to legs to torso to shoulders to neck to head to fingertips.
5. Gratitude pause: "Think of all the people that came before, all the little choices they had to make for you to be here right now in this place."
6. Jesse references *The Four Agreements* by Don Miguel Ruiz and may recommend students read it. Three agreements follow:
 - **Take a risk** - do something you haven't done before.
 - **Release judgment of others** in the room.
 - **Release judgment of yourself** for the length of class.
7. Return to breath: three deep breaths with hands raised high, released with an audible sigh.
8. Open eyes.

What success looks like

Students enter class present, risk-ready, and with reduced self-monitoring - ready to commit and fail visibly.

Participant cues

- The meditation runs 5-10 minutes - arrive ready to commit to it fully.
- Let the framing work for you even if it's unfamiliar; the functional purpose is presence and openness.
- The three agreements are the heart of it: take a risk, release judgment of others, release judgment of yourself.
- The last agreement is the hardest - put self-judgment away for the length of class and allow play to happen.

Facilitator notes

- This is a Flying Pig house ritual, not a generic warmup - do not substitute or abbreviate casually.
- The three agreements map directly to improv skills: risk to bold offers; releasing judgment of others to acceptance; releasing self-judgment to commitment and recovery.
- Jesse occasionally invites students to notice the *third eye* - the seat of inner vision in the Ajna chakra tradition - as part of the inward awareness phase.
- Students may be surprised by the length, tone, or spiritual framing; a brief warning or introduction can reduce this friction.
- At Flying Pig, Jesse prefers the meditation be done in her established form and sequence.

Warmups

Fast activities for attention, connection, energy, and ensemble readiness.

Zip Zap Zop

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Focus; Eye contact.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: focus / eye contact / reaction speed / recovery

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. The sequence passes in order: Zip to Zap to Zop.
- Each pass requires clear eye contact and a deliberate point to the receiver.
- The sequence resets after Zop and continues.

What success looks like

Passes are fast, clear, and connected - eye contact made before the word lands, no hesitation, mistakes acknowledged and moved through quickly.

Participant cues

- Make eye contact before you say the word - the point and word should arrive together.
- Don't overthink which word comes next; trust the sequence and stay present.
- When you make a mistake, recover quickly and keep the energy moving.

Facilitator notes

- This is a good activity to introduce celebrating failures: raise your hands and say joyfully, "I failed!" - then move on.
- Once players are comfortable, instigate a "war" by passing the sequence right back to the player who sent it to you.
- Encourage players to speed up after a few rounds.
- Beginners start with standard Zip Zap Zop; introduce variants once the base is comfortable.
- Watch for: hesitation before passing, weak eye contact, or players dwelling on mistakes instead of moving through them.

Whiskey Mixers / Misty Vistas / Mr. Whiskers

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Concentration; Presence.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: focus / task switching / phrase-direction tracking

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. The active player makes eye contact, uses an offering gesture, and passes one of three phrases to a target.
- Each phrase sends the pass in a different direction:
 - "Whiskey Mixers" to pass to the left
 - "Mr. Whiskers" to pass to the right
 - "Misty Vistas" to pass to any non-adjacent player
- Mistakes are corrected in place. Speed increases until the tongue-twisters become the challenge.

What success looks like

Players respond to the phrase without hesitation; eye contact and gesture are clear; the circle maintains momentum as speed increases.

Participant cues

- Know the phrase-direction mappings before the round starts - don't learn them under pressure.
- Use eye contact and a clear gesture so your target knows the pass is coming.
- When you mess up the tongue-twister, correct it in place and keep going - don't restart the whole thing.

Facilitator notes

- Walk through the three phrases and directions before starting - the game breaks down fast if players aren't clear on the mappings.
- The tongue-twister difficulty is the fun - let speed build naturally rather than forcing it.
- Watch for players who respond to the wrong direction; that's usually a mapping confusion, not inattention.

Ninja Star

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Commitment; Engagement.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY High
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Skills: physical commitment / energy / trajectory / receiving offers

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. One player mimes throwing a ninja star to any other player, accompanied by a strong martial arts sound.
- The receiver catches the star in a way that matches how it was thrown - honoring its weight, speed, and trajectory.
- The receiver then throws to any other player. The pattern continues.

What success looks like

Each throw and catch feels physically committed; the star maintains consistent weight and energy as it travels around the circle.

Participant cues

- Commit fully to the throw - weak or half-hearted choices break the game.
- When you catch, honor what was thrown: match its weight, speed, and trajectory.
- Martial arts sounds are welcome and encouraged - energy matters more than getting the sound exactly right.

Facilitator notes

- The sound is called a *kiai* (pronounced kee-eye) - a term from Japanese martial arts used to express energy and intent through vocalization.
- A good *kiai* should come from the *chi* - deep in the belly - not from the throat.
- The goal is physical projection and full commitment, not technique or accuracy.
- Watch for: half-committed throws, receivers who ignore trajectory, or energy dropping as the star passes around.

Sound Ball

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Object work; sound/movement matching; trajectory.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: object work / sound/movement matching / trajectory

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. The object begins as a buzzing, softball-sized imaginary object.
- A player throws the ball with a sound to any other player.
- On the catch, the receiver repeats the sound the thrower made.
- Then the receiver creates a new sound and throws to the next player.
- Preserve the object's weight, size, and trajectory throughout.

What success looks like

The object feels consistent and real as it travels around the circle; sounds are honored on the catch and invented freshly on the throw.

Participant cues

- Repeat the sound when you catch - don't skip it or change it immediately.
- Honor the object's weight and size; don't let it drift into something different.
- Track where the object is coming from and receive it at the right trajectory.

Facilitator notes

- It's useful to demonstrate object work by pulling the Sound Ball out of an imaginary cabinet before play begins.
- Coach when the object returns to you - use those moments to reset object consistency.
- Watch for: receivers skipping the catch sound, the object losing its physical properties, or trajectory being ignored.

Where Have Your Fingers Been

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Warm up quick character and scene creation; Practice tiny physical performance through the hands.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group; one active at a time	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Mid-Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: fast tiny scenes / physical specificity / prompt acceptance

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. The group chants: "Where have your fingers been, oh where have your fingers been, whoo, whoo."
- One player gives the next a setting or prompt (e.g., "in the kitchen," "at Starbucks," "on an airplane").
- The receiving player uses their index fingers as characters and acts out a short three-line scene.
- After performing, that player gives a new prompt to the next player. Repeat around the circle.

What success looks like

Fingers behave as committed characters; scenes are brief and clear; players accept prompts quickly and pass good ones.

Participant cues

- Let your fingers be the characters - commit to the puppet logic rather than apologizing for it.
- Keep it short: a simple relationship or conflict is enough for three lines.
- Speed matters more than polish. Start before you have a plan.
- Pass a prompt that's easy and fun to play - specific location, not a mood or concept.

Facilitator notes

- Coaches mainly reinforce the rules and structure rather than heavily coaching scene content.
- Watch for: fingers that just point vaguely instead of playing characters, scenes that run too long, or prompts that are too vague to play quickly.
- Self-consciousness is the biggest blocker - acknowledge the silliness and model commitment.

Tongue Twisters

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Warm up articulation; Improve stage speech clarity.

PLAYERS Whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Low
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Skills: articulation / projection readiness / diction

How it works

- The instructor provides a phrase; there is no fixed Flying Pig list - phrases rotate.
- The group repeats or works the phrase as directed.
- The emphasis is clarity over speed: clean vowels, full consonants, and finished final sounds.

What success looks like

Players finish every sound - including final consonants - at a volume and clarity that would carry to the back of a room.

Participant cues

- Don't rush for speed until the phrase is clear - clarity first, then pace.
- Finish your words: final consonants get swallowed most often.
- Keep vowels open and intentional; don't let them flatten under pressure.

Facilitator notes

- The goal is stage-readiness, not just getting through the phrase - resist letting it become a speed race.
- Watch for: volume dropping as difficulty increases, mumbled consonants, or swallowed endings.
- Suggested phrases: "Red leather, yellow leather, red leather, yellow leather." / "Unique New York, unique New York, you know you need unique New York." / "She sells seashells by the seashore." / "Toy boat, toy boat, toy boat."

A to B

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Warm up associative thinking; Reduce hesitation.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: association / speed / listening / low filter

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. Player 1 says any word.
- Each player immediately responds with the first word that comes to mind - no hesitation.
- The goal is speed and honesty, not cleverness or originality.
- In larger circles, multiple starting words can be active simultaneously.

What success looks like

The circle flows fast and continuously; responses are honest rather than clever; players stop monitoring themselves and just play.

Participant cues

- Say the first word that comes to mind - the "obvious" association is usually the right one.
- Don't pause to evaluate whether your response is interesting or funny.
- Try not to repeat a word someone else has already used.
- In A to C, your job is to step past the most predictable word into the next connected idea.
- In No Nouns, watch for yourself defaulting to objects, names, or places.
- Once comfortable, challenge yourself with a different methodology - rhyming, matching the first letter or sound, or starting with the last letter or sound of the previous word.

Facilitator notes

- The exercise is about lowering the filter, not expanding vocabulary - keep the emphasis on momentum.
- Start multiple words simultaneously in large circles to increase load and force presence.
- Encourage students to reflect on how they find their word - is the association based on sound, color, feeling, or something else?
- Watch for: players trying to be funny, pausing too long, responding to a previous word rather than the most recent one, or the circle slowing into polite caution.

Bunny Bunny

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Build group rhythm; Warm up focus and reaction speed.

PLAYERS	TIME	DIFFICULTY	ENERGY
Circle / whole group	3-10 min	High	High

Skills: rhythm / focus / commitment / recovery

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. The group establishes a rhythmic chant underneath: "Kum-chak-a, Kum-chak-a."
- The active player holds up two fingers on each hand as the bunny. Fingers toward self: "Bunny bunny." Fingers toward another player: "Bunny bunny" - passing the bunny to them.
- The receiving player repeats: bunny toward self, then bunny toward someone else.
- The players immediately to either side of the active bunny raise their hands and say "Ticky tocky, ticky tocky."
- Speed increases over time until it becomes controlled chaos.

What success looks like

The chant stays strong; bunny passes are clear and directed; side players hit their cues; the group keeps its energy through mistakes.

Participant cues

- Make your bunny pass clear and directed - vague gestures lose the circle.
- Stay in the chant even when you're not the active bunny; it holds everyone together.
- Watch your neighbors - the "Ticky tocky" role arrives fast and without warning.

Facilitator notes

- Establish the chant before adding the bunny pass; the rhythm is the foundation.
- Add "Ticky tocky" only after the basic pass is stable.
- The goal is collective focus under playful pressure - perfection isn't the point, recovery is.

Bibbity Bibbity Bop

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Build focus and reaction speed; Train players to listen precisely under pressure.

PLAYERS	TIME	DIFFICULTY	ENERGY
Circle plus center player	3-10 min	High	High

Skills: rule tracking / side-player awareness / reaction speed

How it works

- One player starts in the center and points at circle players with one of the calls below. If the targeted player or a required side player fails, they swap into the center.
- Rules are added gradually, not all at once.

"Bibbity Bibbity Bop"

- Target: Say "Bop" before the center finishes their last "Bop."

"Bop"

- Target: Say nothing. Any response = fail.

"Washing Machine"

- Target: Washing machine sounds + hands moving back and forth (7 sec).
- Sides: Say "Chugga Chugga" while moving hands toward the target.

"Elephant"

- Target: Elephant trunk with arms + trumpet sound (7 sec).
- Sides: Form the elephant's ears with their hands.

"Red Baron"

- Target: Goggles with hands + crashing plane scream (7 sec).
- Sides: Arms out straight as wings - both tilt the same direction.

"Charlie's Angels"

- Target: Mime gun upright, say "Freeze" sassily (7 sec).
- Left side: Karate-chop pose.
- Right side: Talking-into-radio pose.

What success looks like

The circle stays alert; side players support without delay; mistakes produce quick swaps, not embarrassment; physical images are big and readable.

Participant cues

- You're always potentially active - stay ready even when you're not the target.
- The side-player roles are as important as the targeted-player role.
- Commit physically and vocally. Small, tentative responses break the energy.

Facilitator notes

- Add rules gradually - don't introduce all six calls at once.
- The center player should vary targets and calls to keep the whole circle alert.
- Watch for players who only track whether they're targeted and stop watching their neighbors - the adjacent obligations are the harder skill.

Zoom, Schwartz, Mafigliano

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Build focus and reaction speed; Practice passing attention clearly.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY High
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Skills: rule tracking / directionality / blocking / recovery

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. One player is active at a time and uses a call to pass to someone else. Rules are added gradually.

"Zoom" - Pass to any non-adjacent player. Cannot be used if you received a Zoom.

"Mafigliano" - Pass to the player immediately to your left or right.

"Schwartz" - Block an incoming pass. The passer must redirect. Schwartz does not make you active.

"Bork" - Look left or right - pass goes one player past that neighbor (a skip).

"Twizzler" - Look left or right - pass goes to the player behind you.

"Twizzler Bork" - Look left or right - pass goes to the player on the far side of the player behind you.

"ZoomaZoomaZooma" - Pass to a non-adjacent player, who must ZoomaZoomaZooma to another, who must do the same. Always a forced chain of three. A Schwartzed ZoomaZoomaZooma is not canceled; you must pick another target.

What success looks like

Passes are clear and fast; the circle tracks the active player; blocks are handled cleanly; later rules increase energy rather than collapsing the game.

Participant cues

- Stay engaged even when you're not active - Zoom and ZoomaZoomaZooma can arrive without warning.
- Make eye contact, point decisively, speak loudly. Vague passes create confusion.
- When you mess up, correct fast and keep going. Don't stop to explain.

Facilitator notes

- Start with Zoom and Mafigliano only. Add Schwartz next, then Bork and Twizzler, then ZoomaZoomaZooma last.
- ZoomaZoomaZooma requires chain tracking - don't introduce it until the basic pass/block mechanics are solid.
- The game works best when confusion is treated as part of the fun rather than a reason to stop.

I Like Butts

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Warm up rhythm; Practice simple rhyming.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Mid-Low	ENERGY High
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Skills: rhythm / rhyme / vocal commitment

How it works

- Players stand in a circle and slap their thighs to establish a beat.
- The group sings the setup phrase twice: "I like butts, um um um."
- Players then take turns adding a rhyming "I like butts that..." line to the same beat. Each line must rhyme with the previous player's ending.
- Keep pace. Easy rhymes beat clever ones every time.
- Example: "I like butts that are big and hairy." / "I like butts that are small and airy."

What success looks like

The beat stays consistent; players commit and land their lines; near-rhymes delivered confidently are fine; nobody stops to judge.

Participant cues

- Listen for the final sound of the previous line - that's what you're rhyming with, not the whole sentence.
- Simple and on-beat beats clever and late.
- Near-rhymes are okay. Deliver them confidently and keep moving.

Facilitator notes

- Keep the thigh-slap beat audible - it's the lifeline for players who struggle with rhyming under pressure.
- Don't let players pause to evaluate their own rhyme. Land it and move on.
- If the group is struggling with rhyme in general, simpler drills before adding beat pressure will help more than repetition.

Bad Rap

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Anti-rhyme; listening for expected rhyme; rhythm; quick verbal choice.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY High
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Skills: anti-rhyme / rhythm / listening / surprise

How it works

- Players stand in a circle and take turns in order.
- Player 1 delivers a two-line rap. The first line ends naturally; the second line is set up to rhyme - but they stop just before the final word.
- The next player completes the line with a word that makes sense but does not rhyme.
- That player then starts a new two-line rap for the next person. Repeat around the circle.
- Example: "I went to the store to buy some bread / I came home and ate a lettuce... leaf."

What success looks like

The circle flows with minimal pauses; setups create clear rhyme expectations; anti-rhymes land as surprise without stopping the rhythm.

Participant cues

- Set up an obvious rhyme - the clearer the expectation, the better the break.
- The anti-rhyme should still make grammatical sense; nonsense is fine, incoherence isn't.
- Don't overthink the anti-rhyme. Quick and wrong beats slow and clever.

Facilitator notes

- Coach players to set up a clear, obvious rhyme - vague setups make the anti-rhyme land flat.
- Keep the energy up; hesitation kills the rhythm more than a weak anti-rhyme does.
- Watch for players who accidentally rhyme - celebrate it as a mistake and move on.

Pass the Clap

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Build eye contact; Build group focus.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: eye contact / timing / shared impulse

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. One player locks eyes with any other player.
- The two players attempt to clap at exactly the same time.
- The receiver then locks eyes with another player and passes the clap.
- The clap may go to any player in the circle, including the one who just passed it.
- The goal is a clean shared clap - connection matters more than speed.

What success looks like

Claps feel simultaneous and mutual - like two people arriving at the same moment together rather than one person signaling and the other reacting.

Participant cues

- Establish real eye contact before initiating - don't clap until you both know it's happening.
- A clean slow clap is better than a rushed messy one.
- Don't anticipate; wait for the shared moment to emerge.
- Missed claps are useful feedback, not failures - recover and move on.

Facilitator notes

- Eye contact is the setup; the clap is the agreement - not the other way around.
- This exercise reveals who is actually connecting versus who is performing the idea of connection.
- Strong players make the receiving player feel seen and clear before initiating.
- Watch for: players clapping before real contact is made, rushing the pass, or becoming self-conscious after a miss.

Pass the Face

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Build close observation; Practice physical and vocal mirroring.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: observation / physical/vocal mimicry / exact transmission

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. One player turns to the next and offers a facial expression, movement, and sound.
- The receiving player watches closely, then turns to the next player and repeats it as accurately as possible.
- The offer passes around the circle, naturally evolving through honest repetition. Multiple passes may run simultaneously in larger groups.
- Reflect the version you received - not the original, and not an improved version.

What success looks like

Players commit fully to face, body, and sound; the offer mutates gradually through honest copying rather than lazy simplification or random exaggeration.

Participant cues

- Copy the player who passed to you - not the one who started it.
- Everything matters: face, head angle, posture, sound, rhythm. Most players only copy the obvious feature.
- Commit even if it feels silly. Laughing or breaking is what flattens the offer.

Facilitator notes

- The exercise is about receiving and transmitting, not improving. Coach players to resist the urge to "fix" the offer back toward the original.
- Watch for simplification - players often believe they're copying accurately when they've only captured the most obvious feature.
- Strong execution preserves the full physical score: eye shape, mouth, head angle, shoulders, weight, rhythm, breath, pitch, volume.

123454321

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Presence; Mental flexibility.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Mid-Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: working memory / pattern tracking / accuracy

How it works

- Players stand in a circle and count sequentially: 1 to 2 to 3 to 4 to 5 to 4 to 3 to 2 to 1, then repeat.
- Each player says the next number in the sequence. The goal is speed, accuracy, and listening.
- When a mistake is made, the group corrects it in place until the right number is supplied - other players may give visual cues to help.

What success looks like

The circle keeps a steady pace, corrections are quick and supportive, and players track the descending half of the pattern as confidently as the ascending.

Participant cues

- The tricky part is the descending half - stay present after 5 and don't rush back to 1.
- When you make a mistake, stay calm; the group will help you find the right number.
- Pay attention for the substitutions. Stay present so you know your order when it arrives at you, and whether you need to make a substitution.

Facilitator notes

- Keep the emphasis on group rhythm and recovery - not embarrassment when someone stumbles.
- Substitutions should be added one at a time and should include different body movements - for instance, one that involves your legs and one that involves your hands.
- Watch for: players freezing after a mistake, helpers being too loud and disruptive, or the circle losing pace after the 5.

Mind Meld

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Practice associative thinking; Build shared mental pathways between players.

PLAYERS Pairs within group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: association / convergence / eye contact / commitment

How it works

- Two players lock eyes and pump one hand in a karate-chop motion while counting down: "3, 2, 1." On the count, each says a word simultaneously.
- A new pair then locks eyes and tries to say the same word - connecting the two words the previous pair said.
- If they match, success. If not, the next pair uses those two new words as their bridge. Continue until two players say the same word at the same time.
- No repeating words that have already been said in the round.
- Example: Pair 1 says "dog" / "house" to Pair 2 aims for something like "kennel" or "yard" - both words, not just one.

What success looks like

Players commit instantly and vocally; the group converges without debate; misses move quickly to the next pair rather than stalling.

Participant cues

- The goal is convergence, not originality - obvious is good.
- Connect both previous words, not just the one you find more interesting.
- Commit vocally and physically. Hesitation makes it harder for your partner to meet you.

Facilitator notes

- Passive players weaken this exercise - convergence requires choosing, not waiting for the obvious answer to appear.
- Don't let players debate or explain a miss; move immediately to the next pair.
- Eye contact is part of the exercise - it's about shared timing and mutual impulse, not just vocabulary.
- Flying Pig plays this in rounds of three - the game continues until the group achieves three successful matches.

Dona Nobis Pacem

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Split the class into two groups to sing different but compatible vocal parts simultaneously; build ensemble listening and vocal commitment.

PLAYERS Whole class; split into two groups	TIME 5-10 min estimated	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Low-Medium
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Skills: listening / vocal commitment / ensemble timing / holding a part / breath support / group cohesion

Setup notes

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

How it works

- The class is split into two groups.
- Each group learns a different vocal part - two compatible melodies sung simultaneously.
- Both groups sing at the same time, listening to each other while holding their own part.

What success looks like

Both parts stay distinct; players remain committed and audible; the group holds together without one part collapsing into the other.

Participant cues

- Sing out - volume and commitment matter more than musical accuracy.
- Listen to the other group without abandoning your own part.
- This isn't a singing test. It's an ensemble exercise.

Facilitator notes

- The useful improv skill here is staying present and committed while something else is happening alongside you.
- Watch for one group losing its part when the other enters - coach them to hold before speeding up.
- Players who are self-conscious about singing need permission to be imperfect out loud.

Big Booty

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: A high-energy rhythm and focus warmup where players chant, slap thighs, track shifting numbers, and pass calls while staying on beat.

PLAYERS Whole group	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY High
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Skills: rhythm / focus / listening / number tracking / vocal commitment / recovery

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. One player is Big Booty; the rest are numbered in order.
- The group establishes a shared rhythm using thigh slaps and chanting.
- The group opens with the chant, then Big Booty starts the call sequence. Each player calls their own name/number, then passes to another.
- If a player misses the rhythm, says the wrong number, or hesitates too long, they move to the end and numbers shift. Reset quickly and keep going.

Example:

- Everyone: "Big Booty, Big Booty, Big Booty - ah Big Booty"
- Big Booty: "Big Booty, Number 4."
- Number 4: "Number 4, Number 7."
- Number 7: "Number 7, Big Booty."

What success looks like

The group holds a clear rhythm; players respond loudly and quickly; mistakes produce laughter and reset energy rather than embarrassment.

Participant cues

- Keep the thigh-slap rhythm going - it supports everyone, not just you.
- Know your current number after each reset; that's the hardest part.
- When you mess up, reset fast and loud. Collapsing the energy is worse than the mistake.

Facilitator notes

- Start slowly enough that the group can succeed, then increase speed once the structure is stable.
- After each reset, confirm everyone knows their new number before restarting.
- The point is not perfection - it's shared rhythm, attention, and recovery. Keep it moving.

Exercises

Skill-building structures for deliberate practice and coaching.

D'Jever

WARMUP / FOCUS EXERCISE

Purpose: Practice building a coherent sentence one word at a time; Encourage players to listen to the developing grammar of the offer.

PLAYERS Circle / sequence	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Mid-Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: one-word sentence construction / restraint / clean endings

How it works

- Players stand in a circle. Player 1 begins with "D'jever" (short for "Did you ever").
- Player 2 adds a verb. Each following player adds one word at a time.
- The sentence ends at its first reasonable completion point - the next player starts a new sentence with "D'jever."
- Example: "D'jever" to "eat" to "a" to "sandwich" to "while" to "crying?"

What success looks like

Sentences complete cleanly at their first natural ending; players serve the sentence rather than forcing a clever turn; restarts are confident.

Participant cues

- Listen for grammar and rhythm - your job is to serve the sentence, not surprise everyone.
- End at the first reasonable completion; don't keep adding clauses to make it funnier.
- Don't hesitate searching for a clever word - a simple word that fits is always right.

Facilitator notes

- Coach players to end at the first reasonable completion - this is the core discipline of the exercise.
- A clear, simple question is better than a long, tortured one.
- Watch for: sentences extended past their natural end, players trying to force a joke, or grammatically tangled constructions.

Mirroring

EXERCISE

Purpose: Physical listening; Awareness.

PLAYERS Pairs	TIME 5-20 min depending reps	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Low
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Skills: physical listening / shared leadership / observation

How it works

Two players face each other and begin moving simultaneously, creating the illusion that neither is leading. One player initiates subtly; leadership passes back and forth without announcement or visible handoff. The goal is seamless, undetectable shared movement - neither clearly leading, neither clearly following.

What success looks like

An outside observer cannot identify who is leading; transitions between leaders are invisible; the pair moves as a single unit; the pace stays slow enough that true copying is possible.

Participant cues

- The illusion of no leader matters more than clever movement.
- Move slowly enough that your partner can actually copy you.
- Leadership should pass back and forth naturally, not through an announced handoff.

Facilitator notes

- One player obviously leads for too long.
- The follower waits passively instead of contributing to shared motion.
- Leadership changes are too abrupt.
- The illusion of no leader matters more than clever movement.
- Move slowly enough that your partner can actually copy you.

I Am a Tree

EXERCISE

Purpose: Yes-And; Association.

PLAYERS Circle; 3 in center at a time	TIME 5-20 min depending reps	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: yes-and / association / embodiment / group composition

How it works

Player 1 strikes a pose and announces what they are ("I am a tree"). Player 2 joins the image and names something related ("I am a cat in the tree"). Player 3 adds a third element connected to the existing image. Player 1 then says "I'll take ____" - choosing one of the two other players to stay. The two not chosen leave. The remaining player becomes the new anchor and names themselves again, and the cycle repeats.

What success looks like

Each new image has a clear spatial and conceptual relationship; players join the image quickly without over-thinking; the anchor player's choice creates surprising but logical new directions; energy stays high and physical.

Participant cues

- Modify the immediately previous object.
- Join the game rather than staying safely outside the circle.
- Embody the offer physically.
- Abstract concepts are allowed and often praised when they are clear and playable.

Facilitator notes

- If players are modifying the wrong object, stop and restate the rule: always add to the immediately previous object, not an earlier one.
- Coach players who stay too literal - the best associations are surprising but logical, not the first obvious thing.
- Watch for weak physical choices. The offers need to be readable from across the room; push for size and commitment.
- Encourage reluctant players to step in - staying safely outside the circle is its own failure mode.

3-Line Scenes

EXERCISE

Purpose: Relationship; Gifting.

PLAYERS Two players	TIME 5-20 min depending reps	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: relationship / gifting / emotional clarity / initiation

How it works

1. Opening gift
2. Response and gift
3. Follow-up

What success looks like

Relationship; Gifting.

Participant cues

- One of Flying Pig's core exercises.
- Frequently the final exercise before stage games.

Facilitator notes

- Watch for vague relationships - if you can't tell how these two people know each other, the scene has no foundation. Stop and ask: who are these people to each other?
- Coach players out of question-answer patterns. Questions put the work on the other player; statements make offers.
- Push for emotional clarity. The emotion should be readable in the body, not just implied by the words.

One Minute Scenes

EXERCISE

Purpose: Practice fast scene initiation; Build playable who/what/where quickly.

PLAYERS Two players	TIME 5-20 min depending reps	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: fast initiation / relationship / emotional readability / continuation

How it works

Two players are given a relationship or starting point. They have one minute to establish and play a full scene with clear who/what/where and emotional stakes. The coach may call time, redirect, or reset mid-scene. The focus is speed of initiation - get to something playable as fast as possible.

What success looks like

Within the first 15-20 seconds the relationship is clear and the emotion is readable; by the midpoint the scene has stakes; the players are reacting to each other rather than performing at the audience.

Facilitator notes

- Watch for scenes that take too long to establish relationship - coach players to land who they are to each other in the first exchange.
- Push back on scenes built around setting or premise with no emotional stakes. Where are the feelings?
- Coaching here closely resembles 3-Line Scene coaching. Common targets include emotional clarity, relationship specificity, and avoiding question-answer patterns.

Pass the Muppet

EXERCISE

Purpose: Character creation; Point of view.

PLAYERS Circle; 4-person cycle	TIME 5-20 min depending reps	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: fast character / POV / vocal/physical commitment

How it works

One player describes a character aloud to the group: name, a brief physical description, and an occupation or role. A designated player must immediately deliver exactly one line of dialogue as that character, revealing their point of view. No extended scene is played - just one strong, committed line. Then repeat with a new character description.

What success looks like

The one line instantly communicates the character's voice, worldview, and personality; the combination of name, physicality, and role collapses into a single readable impulse; an observer could cast that character in a full scene based on that line alone.

Participant cues

- Player 4 should make one strong character offer, not perform a whole scene.
- The line should reveal the character's point of view quickly.
- The best offers combine the name, description, and role into one readable character impulse.
- Physical and vocal commitment help the character read instantly.

Facilitator notes

- Player 4 turns the moment into a full scene instead of delivering one line.
- Player 4 gives a generic line that does not reflect the name, description, or job.
- The one-line character has no clear voice, body, or point of view.
- Player 4 should make one strong character offer, not perform a whole scene.
- The line should reveal the character's point of view quickly.

Tell a Story One Word at a Time

EXERCISE

Purpose: Momentum; Acceptance.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 5-20 min depending reps	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: grammar / listening / shared story / momentum

How it works

- Players stand in a circle.
- The teacher prompts the group with a starter phrase.
- The most common starter is:
 - "Once upon a time..."

What success looks like

- The story moves quickly.
- Each word makes grammatical sense.
- Players support the sentence rather than fighting for control.
- Connector words appear when needed.
- The story reaches a clear natural ending.
- The teacher can call "The End" cleanly because the group has landed the story together.

Participant cues

- Speed matters, but the word still needs to make sense.
- The story does not need to be brilliant; it needs to keep moving.
- Connector words are often the most important support words.
- A simple word that preserves grammar is usually better than a clever word that breaks the sentence.

Facilitator notes

- The main failure mode is hesitation - coach players to say something, anything, without waiting for the perfect word.
- Watch for players trying to control the story. The job is to follow, not to steer.
- Coach players who skip necessary connector words (articles, prepositions). The sentence still needs to be grammatical.
- Speed matters, but the word still needs to make sense.

Neverending Story

EXERCISE

Purpose: Narrative causality; Listening.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 5-20 min depending reps	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: causality / narrative structure / consequence

How it works

- Players stand in a circle.
- The teacher leads the structure by supplying story prompts.
- Players complete each prompt with one sentence.

What success looks like

- Each sentence follows clearly from the previous sentence.
- The story develops through cause and effect.
- Players do not contradict earlier information.
- The repeated "Because of that..." beats build momentum rather than randomness.
- The final "ever since then" and moral feel earned by the story.

Participant cues

- "Because of that..." means the next sentence should be a consequence.
- The player should ask: "What happened because of the sentence immediately before mine?"
- The story does not need to be clever; it needs cause and effect.
- Each sentence should preserve what came before.

Facilitator notes

- Breaking causality.
- Responding to an earlier story beat instead of the immediately previous one.
- Modifying a beat that was not directly previous to the player's turn.
- "Because of that..." means the next sentence should be a consequence.
- The player should ask: "What happened because of the sentence immediately before mine?"

Things a Cowboy Says

EXERCISE

Purpose: Group mind; Shared sentence construction.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 5-20 min depending reps	DIFFICULTY Mid-Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: sentence completion / restraint / group timing

How it works

- Players stand in a circle.
- The group builds a cowboy-style saying one word at a time.
- No fixed starter phrase is used - the saying begins from the first player's word.
- The saying begins from the first player's word.

What success looks like

- The sentence is grammatical.
- The saying feels cowboy-flavored enough to fit the exercise.
- The group recognizes the first natural ending.
- "YEE HAW" lands cleanly.
- The sentence does not get dragged past completion.

Participant cues

- Grammar matters.
- The group should listen for when the sentence has become complete.
- "YEE HAW" should be called at the first clean ending, not after the sentence has been overextended.
- Like D'Jever, the exercise trains players to recognize completion and stop.

Facilitator notes

- Coach players who break grammar - the sentence needs to be a real sentence, even if the content is absurd.
- Watch for players who keep adding words after the sentence is already complete. Coach them to hear the natural ending and stop there.
- The group should listen actively for when the sentence has closed - that's the skill being trained.

Space and Object Work

EXERCISE

Purpose: Develop believable object work; Build physical specificity.

PLAYERS Whole class individually	TIME 5-20 min depending reps	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Low
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Skills: object permanence / silent specificity / environment

How it works

- The teacher gives the class a simple physical prompt.
- Examples include:
 - getting yourself a glass of water,
 - looking through an old photo album,
 - arriving home from work.
- The entire class performs the action silently.
- Students repeat the action sequence multiple times.
- The teacher walks around the room and gives individual critiques.
- The exercise focuses on precision, physical clarity, and consistency rather than dialogue or scene invention.

What success looks like

Develop believable object work; Build physical specificity.

Participant cues

- Treat imaginary objects as physically real.
- Decide where the object is and keep it there.
- Maintain consistent size, weight, and distance.
- Slow down enough for the audience to read the action.

Facilitator notes

- Watch for objects that change size, height, or location mid-exercise. Stop and reset: decide where the object is and keep it there.
- Coach players who rush through actions without detail - slow down and find the physical reality of the object.
- Push back on vague hand-waving. Specific physical interaction means knowing exactly where your hands are and what they're touching.

5 Second Delay

EXERCISE

Purpose: Slow players down; Increase listening.

PLAYERS Two players	TIME ~3 min per student; short reps recommended (prior run ~60 min for 14 students)	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Low-Medium
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Skills: alive silence / listening / emotional reaction / patience

How it works

- Two players perform a scene.
- Players must leave at least five seconds between lines of dialogue.
- During the silence, players should remain active through:
 - eye contact,
 - physical behavior,
 - emotional reaction,
 - object work,
 - status shifts,
 - listening,
 - letting the previous line affect them.
- The scene continues normally, but the pace of spoken dialogue is deliberately slowed.
- The delay applies between lines, not merely between speeches.

What success looks like

Slow players down; Increase listening.

Participant cues

- The silence must stay alive.
- The goal is not merely to count to five; the goal is to let the previous offer affect the character.
- During the delay, players should do something playable:
 - react emotionally,
- This game trains what "slow down" actually means: not slower thinking, but non-verbal life between lines - space work, object work, physical reaction before speech.

Facilitator notes

- Watch for players who forget the delay and respond immediately - stop and reset the rule.
- Coach players who become visibly anxious during the silence. The pause is part of the scene, not a gap to survive.
- Push players to treat the silence as playable time, not dead air. Something is happening in that 5 seconds.
- The silence must stay alive.

Secrets

EXERCISE

Purpose: Each player draws a private secret from a box before the scene; play the scene letting the secret shape behavior without announcing it; guess partner's secret after.

PLAYERS Two players	TIME 5-15 min estimated	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: subtext / character want / emotional point of view / listening / inference / playing need without exposition / partner observation / emotional specificity

Setup notes

Materials: Box of secret prompts

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

How it works

- Do not directly state your secret.
- Do not turn the scene into interrogation or a guessing game during the scene.
- Let the secret affect what you want, how you listen, how you react, and what you avoid.
- The secret should influence the character without replacing the relationship, setting, or scene action.
- The scene still needs a clear who, what, and where.
- The secret should create playable subtext, not private mental trivia.

What success looks like

- Each character has a clear behavioral tilt from the secret.
- The scene still has a grounded relationship and situation.
- The secrets create tension, surprise, emotional specificity, or vulnerability.
- The players do not directly reveal their secrets.
- At the end, the guesses are at least directionally connected to what was played.
- The audience or class can see how the secret influenced the performance.
- The scene feels deeper because the characters are carrying private wants or wounds.

Participant cues

- The secret should shape behavior, not become dialogue.
- A secret can create: need, grief, avoidance, urgency, insecurity, guilt, hope, desperation, emotional guardedness, or status behavior.
- The scene should remain playable even if nobody guesses the secret correctly.
- A successful scene does not require a perfect guess.

Facilitator notes

- A player blurts out their secret.
- A player hints so obviously that the scene becomes a guessing game.
- A player hides the secret so completely that it has no effect.
- The secret should shape behavior, not become dialogue.
- A secret can create: need, grief, avoidance, urgency, insecurity, guilt, hope, desperation, emotional guardedness, or status behavior.

Gets Emotional

EXERCISE

Purpose: Each player receives two adjectives and a first name from classmates; build and play a character from those combined descriptors in a two-or-three-person scene.

PLAYERS	TIME	DIFFICULTY	ENERGY
Two scene players (gets supplied by off-stage students)	1-2 min per scene	Mid	Medium-High

Skills: character creation / emotional readability / physical embodiment / vocal commitment / point of view / accepting gifts / combining contradictory traits / specificity

Setup notes

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

How it works

- Prep: each student thinks of three real people they know - a first name and one personality descriptor.
- Two players go up. Each receives two describing words and one first name, the coach pointing at a different off-stage student for each get - misaligned combinations ("Nervous, Boisterous Henry") are part of the point.
- Both players build a character from their gets and play the scene in character; the coach cuts it, typically around one minute.
- Use the gets to build the character.
- Do not merely announce the adjectives.
- Do not ignore difficult or contradictory descriptors.
- Let the traits affect voice, posture, rhythm, emotional state, status, reactions, and point of view.
- The scene still needs relationship, location, and present action.
- The character should remain playable, not just a list of traits.

What success looks like

- The character reads quickly from the back of the room.
- The player uses all or most of the gets.
- The traits affect behavior throughout the scene.
- The character has a clear point of view.
- The scene still has a relationship and present action.
- The character becomes more playable as the scene continues rather than fading away.
- The audience or class can recognize how the original gets shaped the performance.

Participant cues

- The useful question is: "How does this person behave because they are calm, fiery, excitable, studious, etc.?"
- The name can influence voice, age, status, rhythm, social energy, or worldview.
- Strong players convert adjectives into playable behavior:
 - Calm might mean stillness, low vocal tempo, grounded reactions.

Facilitator notes

- Coach players to embody the traits, not state them.
- Watch for the character going generic despite specific gets.
- Remind players to keep all the gets in play, not just the strongest one.
- The useful coaching question is: "How does this person behave because they are [trait]?"
- Remind players the name can influence voice, age, status, rhythm, and social energy - it's not just a label.

5 Word Cafe

EXERCISE

Purpose: Every spoken line must be five words or fewer; scene is set in a cafe; constraint forces concise dialogue, physical action, and emotional clarity.

PLAYERS 2-3 players	TIME 5-15 min estimated	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: concision / listening / clean offers / editing dialogue internally / emotional readability / physical behavior / subtext / specificity / scene economy

Setup notes

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

How it works

- Every line must be five words or fewer.
- The scene is set in a cafe.
- Players should still establish relationship, action, and emotional point of view.
- The word limit should not become the only interesting thing in the scene.
- Players should not avoid speaking entirely; the exercise is concise dialogue, not silence.
- Physical action and emotional reaction become more important because dialogue is restricted.

What success looks like

- The scene remains active despite limited dialogue.
- Players stay under the five-word limit.
- The cafe setting is used physically.
- Characters have clear wants or emotional states.
- The relationship becomes clear through short lines, behavior, and reaction.
- The constraint creates sharper dialogue rather than dead air.
- The audience or class can still follow the scene.

Participant cues

- The word limit should sharpen the scene, not shrink commitment.
- Short lines still need point of view.
- Physical action can carry information that dialogue cannot.
- Players should use the cafe environment: ordering, serving, cleaning, waiting, spilling, paying, avoiding someone, meeting someone, or confronting someone.
- "Slow down" doesn't mean think slower - fill the space between your five words with space work, object work, and physical reactions. More non-verbal between verbal moments.

Facilitator notes

- Coach players who become so focused on counting that they stop acting. The constraint should sharpen the scene, not replace commitment.
- Push for lines that still carry point of view. Short doesn't mean empty.

10 Characters in 60 Seconds

EXERCISE

Purpose: One player demonstrates 10 distinct characters within 60 seconds; tests character range, physical and vocal transformation speed, and commitment under time pressure.

PLAYERS	TIME	DIFFICULTY	ENERGY
1	1-2 min	High	High

Skills: character range / fast commitment / physical transformation / vocal variety / emotional variety / status shifts / point of view / speed / audition readiness / recovery under pressure

Setup notes

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

How it works

- One player only.
- 10 characters.
- 60 seconds.
- Each character should be distinct.
- The player should not spend time explaining the character.
- The character must be demonstrated through performance choices, not described from the outside.
- The player simply goes while the coach times and counts. Characters are fully player-invented - no prompts.
- Only clearly distinct, readable characters count toward the 10; blurred ones aren't credited.

What success looks like

- The player reaches 10 characters within 60 seconds.
- The characters are clearly distinct.
- The player commits physically and vocally.
- The player uses a wide emotional and status range.
- The transitions are fast.
- The audience or auditors can immediately tell that a new character has appeared.
- The player does not apologize, explain, or collapse after weak choices.

Participant cues

- Each character needs an immediate visible difference.
- Strong changes may come from: posture, face, tempo, voice placement, emotional state, status, age, rhythm, physical center, or point of view.
- The exercise rewards boldness over nuance.
- A simple but committed character is better than a subtle underplayed one.
- You may perform more than 10 - only the readable ones count. Distinctness beats quantity.

Facilitator notes

- Watch for characters that blur together.
- Coach players who change only voice or only body. Both need to shift together with point of view.
- Remind players that strong changes come from posture, face, tempo, voice placement, emotional state, status, age, rhythm, physical center, or point of view.

It's Tuesday

EXERCISE

Purpose: Given a mundane get, perform a solo scene moving through three distinct big emotions; tests emotional range, readability, and the ability to heighten ordinary material.

PLAYERS 1	TIME 2-5 min estimated	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY High
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Skills: emotional range / emotional readability / solo commitment / heightening / justification / emotional transitions / making mundane material playable / vocal and physical expressiveness / audition readiness

Setup notes

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

How it works

- The get should be mundane.
- The player performs alone.
- The player must demonstrate three big emotions.
- The emotions should be distinct, not slight variations of the same feeling.
- The player should not merely name the emotions.
- The emotional states should be performed through voice, body, face, rhythm, point of view, and behavior.
- The ordinary get should remain connected to the scene.
- Exactly three emotions - the player calls their own ending after the third. The get comes from the coach or the class.

What success looks like

- The player creates three clearly different emotional states.
- Each emotion is physically and vocally readable.
- The mundane get remains the anchor.
- The emotional progression feels heightened but playable.
- The player commits without apology.
- The scene has momentum rather than feeling like three disconnected demonstrations.
- The audience or auditors can easily identify the emotional shifts.

Participant cues

- The point is not realism; the point is emotional availability and readability.
- Mundane material is useful because it forces the player to supply the stakes.
- Strong emotional choices might include: panic, joy, grief, shame, awe, rage, desperation, heartbreak, ecstatic confidence, confusion, fear, or overwhelming relief.
- Each emotional shift should have a playable reason, even if the reason is heightened or absurd.
- Link each shift to a change in the scene - don't jump directly from one emotion to the next. Use movement, not just voice.
- End after three: sneaking in a fourth, or calling it with only two readable, are the classic mistakes.
- If told to "slow down," it means react physically before speaking and let non-verbal work carry the emotional shifts - not think slower.

Facilitator notes

- The emotions are too small to read.
- The player changes the words but not the body or voice.
- The emotions are not distinct enough.
- The point is not realism; the point is emotional availability and readability.

- Mundane material is useful because it forces the player to supply the stakes.

Best Friends

EXERCISE

Purpose: A two-and-a-half-player scene exercise where two players match emotional, physical, and vocal energy as distinct aligned characters, then a third player enters near the end with opposing energy.

PLAYERS 2.5 players / 3 with delayed third entrance	TIME 3-6 min per rep	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium-High
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Skills: energy matching / partner listening / emotional synchronization / physical/vocal alignment / contrast / shared worldview

How it works

- Two players begin the scene.
- The coach gives them a simple word suggestion.
- The first two players use the word to initiate a scene.
- The scene runs primarily as a two-person scene.
- The two players should play distinct characters while matching each other's emotional, physical, and vocal energy.
- A third player enters near the end with opposing energy.

What success looks like

- The first two players feel strongly connected.
- Their shared energy is readable quickly.
- The audience can tell why these two characters belong together.
- The characters remain distinct while sharing emotional/physical/vocal tone.
- The third player's entrance creates immediate contrast.
- The contrast reveals something about the first two players.
- The scene ends soon after the disruption lands.
- The exercise sharpens partner awareness and energy matching.

Participant cues

- The first two players should quickly identify and heighten a shared energy.
- Matching means emotional, physical, and vocal alignment, not identical behavior.
- Distinct characters can still share the same rhythm, intensity, attitude, and worldview.
- The third player should make a clean, contrasting offer.

Facilitator notes

- The first two players do not match energy clearly.
- The players copy each other mechanically instead of sharing a playable energy.
- The players become identical rather than distinct aligned characters.
- The first two players should quickly identify and heighten a shared energy.
- Matching means emotional, physical, and vocal alignment, not identical behavior.

Status Inversion

EXERCISE

Purpose: A two-player status drill where players receive an uneven relationship, then reverse the actual power dynamic while keeping the external roles intact.

PLAYERS Two players	TIME 1-3 min per rep	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: status / power dynamics / relationship clarity / physical status / vocal status / audience readability

How it works

Two players are assigned an uneven relationship with a clear external hierarchy (boss/employee, teacher/student, parent/child). The player in the lower-status role must hold the actual power while maintaining the appearance of deference. The higher-status role must yield real control without appearing to. Status is expressed physically and vocally, not just through dialogue.

What success looks like

The audience can clearly read both the official hierarchy and the inverted real power simultaneously; status shifts are visible in body language, space, and voice - not just in what is said; the inversion feels earned through behavior rather than stated.

Turn and Count

EXERCISE

Purpose: Group stands in a circle facing outward and attempts to count together without anyone speaking simultaneously - building group mind without visual cues.

PLAYERS Whole class	TIME 10-20 min	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Low
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Skills: group mind / active listening / presence / restraint

Setup

The group stands in a circle, then all turn to face outward so no one can see anyone else.

How it works

- Players count upward together, one number per speaker, in no fixed order - any player may say any number.
- If two players speak at the same time, the count resets to 1 and the group tries again.
- There is no signal, no turn order, and no coordination other than listening.

What success looks like

The group sustains a long count without collision. High counts require the ensemble to develop a shared sense of timing and an instinct for when to hold back versus step forward.

Participant cues

- Restraint is as important as initiative. Knowing when *not* to speak is the skill.
- Don't try to "plan" when you'll speak - stay present and let the number arrive naturally.
- A long count feels different from a short one. Notice what changes internally when the group is in sync.

Facilitator notes

- This exercise reveals individual tendencies clearly: some players count frequently, others rarely. Neither extreme is ideal - the goal is shared initiative.
- It also tests willingness to protect the group. Players who hold back too much are leaving the work to others; players who jump in too fast are prioritizing themselves.
- Multiple rounds in a session are normal. The group often improves significantly across rounds, and the jump from a low count to a breakthrough count (e.g., reaching 39) can be a meaningful shared experience.
- No facilitation is needed during the exercise itself - debrief afterward if useful.

Short Form

Self-contained games with a clear premise, pattern, or performance rule.

60 Second Fairy Tale

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Story compression; Editing.

PLAYERS 3-5 performers plus host	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: story compression / time pressure / ensemble coordination

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Roles

Host
Player 1
Player 2
Player 3
Player 4

Optional host introduction

Our next game is called 60 Second Fairy Tale. May I please have a fairy tale or well-known story - something everyone in the room has heard before. [Confirm get. Give players a brief moment to agree on the key beats.] All right - our players are going to perform [get] for you in 60 seconds. Starting ... now!

How it works

- Host gets a fairy tale or well-known story from the audience. At least one player must know it. Players get a brief organizing period - keep it quick.
- Players perform the same story repeatedly, each version compressed into a shorter time limit. The host times each round and calls time.
- Each version should compress the established interpretation - not introduce new beats. The 1-second version is always the finale.
- Time limits: 60 sec to 30 sec to 15 sec to 7 sec to 3.5 sec to 1 sec

What success looks like

The same recognizable story landmarks survive every compression; physical shorthand gets bigger as time shrinks; the 1-second finale lands as a button.

Participant cues

- Agree on the essential beats before you start - you'll be compressing those, not inventing new ones.
- Physical storytelling becomes more important as words disappear. Make it big and readable.
- The story under pressure should feel like the same story, just faster - not a different scene.

Facilitator notes

- Keep the planning period short - long prep kills the energy before the game begins.
- The host should bring energy around each time cut and manage the audience while players organize between rounds.
- Watch for players dropping the main arc in later rounds. The comedy comes from recognizable compression, not random chaos.

Excuses

SHORT FORM

Purpose: A guessing game in which a late employee must piece together the wild excuse stories their co-workers invented on their behalf.

PLAYERS Typically 4-5 players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: guessing / charades support / host/boss steering

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Roles

Boss
Coworker 1
Coworker 2
Late Person

Optional host introduction

Our next game is a guessing game, so we need [Player 1] to step outside. [Player 1 leaves.] [In character as Boss, to coworkers:] Now that they're gone - may I please have a reason someone might be late for work? (audience get) [fake name] is late again. They told me it was (get) - but there's no way (get) would make you this late. [Coworker 1 - Player 2:] Yeah, you don't have the whole story. You see, after (get), they (add a new escalating reason). [Boss:] Wow. Is that all? [Coworker 2 - Player 3:] Not quite. After (Coworker 1's addition), they (add another escalating reason). [Boss:] Well, when they get in here, their story better match yours - or all of you are fired. Before we bring them back - if [Player 1]'s guess is close, give them snaps (demonstrate). If they get it exactly right, give them a clap. Let's bring [Player 1] back in. This is Why Were You Late.

Flying Pig Name

This game is called *Excuses* at Flying Pig. It may appear elsewhere as *Why Were You Late?* or *Late for Work*.

Setup

- Three players: a Boss, two Co-workers, and one Late Person (the guesser).
- The guesser leaves the room.

How it works

1. The Boss solicits a mundane get from the audience - something ordinary and unremarkable. Example: *"Cat vomited on carpet."*
2. The Boss tells the two Co-workers the mundane get, then - staying in character - solicits one outrageous excuse story from each Co-worker. These are big, specific, creative narratives. Examples:
 - *"A troll dropped through the sunroof, and he had to do battle with the troll, and kick him out of the moving car."*
 - *"A whole truckload of Barbies spilled on the interstate, and the co-worker was too much of a gentleman to run over a woman, so he ran over the one and only Ken doll instead, and the Ken doll stuck into his tire and gave him a flat."*
3. The Boss frames the stakes: *"That seems ridiculous. His story had better match yours, or you're all fired."*
4. The Late Person returns and begins guessing - the Co-workers charade their stories while the Late Person works to reconstruct them.

What success looks like

The Late Person narrates an increasingly specific version of the Co-workers' wild stories; the Boss steers without solving; the Co-workers' charades are physical and readable; the excuse story that emerges is recognizably close to what was set up.

Participant cues

- Co-workers: work as a team when charading - you are jointly responsible for conveying all of the excuse stories, not just your own.
- The Late Person: guess actively. Start with category (person? place? action?) and narrow from there.

- Boss: your job is to keep the scene alive and hint without giving it away.

Facilitator notes

- The Boss role is the most critical - they manage the guesser, Co-workers, and audience simultaneously.
 - The mundane get from the audience contrasts with the wild co-worker stories; that contrast is where the comedy lives.
 - Watch for Co-workers who give uncharadeable stories - coach toward visual, physical, breakable-into-parts narratives.
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Freeze Tag

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice initiation; Encourage physicality.

PLAYERS Usually about 6; scalable	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY High
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Skills: physical initiation / justification / edits

Roles

Player 1
Player 2
Player 3
Player 4
Player 5
Player 6

Optional host introduction

Our next game is for all [number] players. [Player 1] and [Player 2] are going to start a scene, and any time they want, another player can shout freeze and take their place. To get us started, may I please have [Letter Get x 2]? [Confirm letters.] [Player 1] and [Player 2], make those letters with your bodies. This is Freeze Tag.

How it works

- The host asks the audience for two letters. The first two players make those letters with their bodies as a starting position.
- Two players begin a scene. Offstage players watch for interesting physical positions.
- An offstage player calls "Freeze!" - both onstage performers stop immediately.
- Flying Pig version: two offstage players enter. Each tags the player they want to replace - the tag is what gives that player permission to leave. Both original performers exit.
- Each new player takes the exact frozen position of the player they tagged, justifies it, and starts a completely new, unrelated scene. Repeat.

What success looks like

New scenes start immediately and distinctly; frozen positions are honored and justified; physical choices are bold enough to inspire real premises.

Participant cues

- Call "Freeze" when the stage picture gives you an idea - not just to get onstage.
- Take the position first; let it tell you the scene, relationship, or environment.
- Create interesting physical pictures while you're onstage so others have something to work with.

Facilitator notes

- The game lives or dies on physicality. Talking-head scenes starve it.
- Coach players to call "Freeze" with a plan, not out of impatience or obligation.
- Watch for new players who ignore the frozen position - the physical picture is the whole point of the edit.

Story, Story, Die!

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice listening; Build verbal agility.

PLAYERS Director plus several storytellers	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY High
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Skills: instant continuation / narrative pressure / playful failure

Setup notes

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Roles

Host / Pointer

Player 1

Player 2

Player 3

Player 4

Player 5

Optional host introduction

Our next game involves all [number] players. I'm going to point at a player and they're going to tell a story. When I switch who I'm pointing at, that player has to continue the story from exactly where the previous player left off. And if they don't continue it perfectly - you're going to yell die. Let's practice. Everyone say die! [Audience yells die.] To get us started, may I please have (audience get - a creature or character). [Confirm get.] And may I please have (audience get - an emotion, name, or adjective; shape it so it will combine naturally with the first get into a title without telegraphing the link). [Confirm get.] The (get two) (get one) - Chapter One.

How it works

Storytellers stand in a line. The director points to one - that player immediately continues a shared story.

The director points to another player at any moment; that player must continue from the exact word where the story was handed off.

If a player hesitates, stutters, or fails to continue instantly, the audience yells "DIE!" - the player gets a death suggestion from the audience, performs it, and becomes a corpse onstage.

The last remaining storyteller delivers the moral of the story. The audience votes whether they live or die.

What success looks like

The story flows seamlessly across players; deaths are quick and funny; the director creates real pressure; the final moral feels like a button.

Participant cues

Continue immediately - don't repeat the previous player's last words to buy time.

Don't plan ahead. Listen. Trust the first continuation that appears.

The story doesn't need to be brilliant; it needs to keep moving.

After elimination, commit to your death and then stay still - don't steal focus as a corpse.

Facilitator notes

Directors: point clearly and switch often enough to create pressure. Hunt kills as the field narrows.

Common failure: players repeat the previous player's final words as a stall - call it immediately.

Watch for players who restart the word or sentence instead of continuing mid-syllable. Coach them to pick up exactly where the previous player left off.

Four Square

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice relationship tracking; Build continuity across multiple scenes.

PLAYERS 4 players plus host	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: scene memory / context switching / relationship tracking

Setup notes

Materials: Open stage space; host rotation calls

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Optional host introduction

We have four players arranged in a square. Each pair is going to play a scene. [Rotate through all four sides, collecting one get per side - "one to the left" between each.] May I please have (audience get - a location or relationship). [Confirm. Rotate. Repeat until all four sides have a get.] Now let's review. [Rotate through all four sides; players announce their get as each faces the audience.] This is Four Square.

How it works

- Once each side has a suggestion, the game begins.
- Only the side facing the audience is active.
- The active pair performs the scene associated with that side.
- At any time, the host may rotate the square.
- Common rotation calls include:
 - "One to the left."
 - "One to the right."
 - "Two to the left."
 - "Two to the right."
- When the square rotates, the newly front-facing side resumes its own scene.
- Each side preserves its own relationship, premise, and emotional history.
- Scenes often return after a time jump rather than resuming from the exact previous second.

What success looks like

- The audience can distinguish all four worlds.
- Relationships remain clear when revisited.
- Time jumps advance the relationship or situation.
- Players immediately know which scene they are in after a rotation.
- The host's rotations create momentum and contrast.
- The game feels like four living scenes rather than four repeated premises.

Participant cues

- Each side needs a distinct relationship and emotional engine.
- When a scene returns, it should continue or advance, not reset.
- Time jumps can help the scene evolve.
- The audience should be able to immediately recognize which scene has returned.
- Emotional stakes and relationship clarity matter more than the rotation mechanic.

- Strong players re-enter the scene with confidence, as if no time has passed for the performers even if time has passed in the world.

Facilitator notes

- Watch for players who lose track of which relationship belongs to which side - stop and clarify before continuing.
 - Coach players who bleed information from one scene into another. Each side is its own world.
 - Watch for players who return to a scene and replay the same emotional beat. Each visit should escalate or reveal something new.
 - Push for scenes that are distinct from each other in tone, energy, and relationship.
 - Host rotations should be unpredictable enough to create surprise once the game is underway, but not so chaotic that scenes can't establish themselves early.
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Three-Headed Expert

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice listening; Build collaborative speaking.

PLAYERS Host plus three experts	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: one-word group speaking / confidence / hosting / audience questions

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Optional host introduction

We are so proud you've joined us today - we have the world's foremost expert on just about anything here to take your questions. First, let's find out who we're talking to. Expert - what is your name? [Players answer one word at a time to build the name.] [One or two warm-up questions to establish rhythm.] Now - who has a question for our expert?

How it works

Three players form a single expert. The host begins by asking the expert their name - the three answer one word at a time.

The host asks one or two warm-up questions to establish the rhythm, then opens the floor to audience questions.

The expert answers every question one word at a time, with total authority, regardless of whether the answer makes sense.

Example audience question: "People are talking about orbital data centers - but given they're limited to radiative heat, how do you recommend they mitigate excess thermal energy?"

What success looks like

The expert sounds like one confident mind; the audience enjoys watching authority applied to impossible questions; the host keeps the rhythm and picks strong questions.

Participant cues

Confidence matters more than correctness. Commit to the answer - the expert always knows.

Don't try to be individually funny. Support the shared sentence. Listen for where it's going.

Treat impossible questions as answerable. The gap between authority and nonsense is the comedy.

Facilitator notes

The host's first questions establish permission - they show the audience what kind of questions make the game work.

Strong audience questions are technical, specialized, philosophical, or otherwise unanswerable by any real person.

Common failure: experts lack confidence and the answer becomes slow and timid. Redirect to authority over accuracy.

Good, Bad, Worse

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice escalation; Create clear contrast.

PLAYERS Host plus three players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: escalation / contrast / concise advice jokes

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Optional host introduction

Our next game is Good, Bad, Worse. We need a topic - a domain where you might ask for advice. Something like dating, parenting, cooking, medicine. May I please have (audience get - a topic or domain). [Confirm get.] [One or two warm-up questions to establish rhythm.] [Audience questions.]

How it works

- Host gets a domain of knowledge from the audience (e.g., dating, medicine, parenting).
- The host assigns the three roles - Good, Bad, Worse - by audience applause vote. The host asks a playful question for each role, and the audience votes by applause for which player fits best.
 - Example for Good: "By applause, who would you trust to cook a tasty soup?"
 - Example for Worse: "By applause, who would look the cutest holding a puppy?"
- Players keep their fixed roles for the entire game.
- The host asks a question in the domain. Good gives reasonable advice. Bad gives bad advice. Worse tops Bad with something more disastrous or absurd.
- Repeat through multiple questions. Roles do not rotate. Host ends the game before the pattern wears out.

What success looks like

The audience immediately hears the progression; Worse reliably tops Bad; answers are short and clear; the contrast between roles is obvious.

Participant cues

- Good establishes the baseline - play it straight so the contrast lands.
- Bad should clearly violate good judgment. Worse should top Bad, not just repeat it.
- Short answers work better. Don't explain the joke - land it and stop.

Facilitator notes

- The most common failure: Bad isn't bad enough, so Worse has nowhere to go. Coach players to commit to their tier.
- The host's questions should make escalation easy - specific, situational prompts beat vague ones.
- Watch for Good playing for jokes - it undermines the contrast the whole game depends on.

The Dating Game

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice character-based hinting; Practice guessing from indirect clues.

PLAYERS	TIME	DIFFICULTY	ENERGY
Guesser, 3 contestants, usually host	5-10 min typical show/practice unit	Mid-High	Medium

Skills: character hinting / guessing / host control

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Roles

Host / MC

Contestant (guesser)

Date 1

Date 2

Date 3

Optional host introduction

Our next game is a guessing game, which means [Player 1] has to leave the room. [Player 1 leaves.] All right, now that they're gone, I need your help setting up the game. May I please have (audience get - assign to Player 2). For [Player 3], may I please have (audience get - assign to Player 3). And for [Player 4], may I please have (audience get - assign to Player 4). Let's bring our contestant back in. Contestant, can I have your name please? [Player 1 gives a fake name.] We have three lovely potential dates for you tonight. This is the Dating Game. [Note: This is an audience-feedback guessing game. Before bringing the guesser back in, teach the audience: snaps for close, clap for exactly right.]

How it works

The guesser leaves. The audience gives three different identity suggestions - each contestant gets one (identities vary by type: animal, profession, character trait, fear, historical figure, etc.).

The guesser returns and asks each contestant ~3-4 dating-show-style questions. Contestants answer in character, hinting without giving away the answer.

Guessing happens at the end - one contestant at a time. If the guesser is close but not exact, the contestant or host gives a hint.

Sample identity set: "Has not slept in three days" · "Forest nymph" · "Chemical engineer"

Strong questions: "Where would you take me on our first date?" · "What gift would you bring my parents?" · "What would ruin our honeymoon?"

What success looks like

Each contestant is distinct and playable; answers are funny while still functioning as hints; the final guesses feel earned; hints close gaps without dragging.

Participant cues

Be helpful but not obvious. Answer through worldview, metaphor, and emotional reaction - not just facts about your identity.

Don't hide so much that the game stalls, but don't give it away in the first answer either.

Let the identity shape everything: voice, posture, word choice, what you find romantic or scary.

Facilitator notes

Choose or shape identities so each contestant has a distinct clue path - three similar identities make the game flat.

Common failure: contestants treat the identity as trivia instead of a playable character. Redirect to behavior and worldview.

The final guessing should be supported, not punitive. Hints from contestants or the host keep the ending from dragging.

Job Interview

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice guessing out loud; Practice giving useful hints while staying in character.

PLAYERS Guesser, 3 interviewers, host	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: guessing / supportive hinting / interview frame

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Roles

Interviewer

Candidate (guesser)

Audience Panelist 1

Audience Panelist 2

Optional host introduction

Our next game is a guessing game, so we need [Player 1] to step outside. [Player 1 leaves.] I need your help setting this up. May I please have an unusual job. [Confirm get.] May I please have somewhere you might work. [Confirm get.] And may I please have something strange to wear. [Confirm get.] [Player 1] is going to come back in as a job applicant. These three are the interviewers - and they're going to ask questions that hint at all three of those things. Before we bring them back - snaps if they're close, clap if they get it exactly right. Let's bring [Player 1] back in. This is Job Interview.

How it works

- The guesser leaves the room. Host gets three hidden audience suggestions: a job, the place where it takes place, and an odd uniform.
- Three players sit as interviewers who know the hidden answers. Guesser returns as the job applicant.
- Interviewers ask questions that contain clues about the hidden components - staying in the interview frame throughout.
- Guesser guesses out loud. Audience snaps = close; claps = correct component.
- Example: Nap Coordinator · Prison · Space Suit.

What success looks like

The guesser keeps guessing out loud; interviewers give clues across all three components; the interview frame stays intact; the final guesses feel earned.

Participant cues

- Guesser: stay in character as the applicant and keep guessing - wrong guesses narrow the search and help the audience root for you.
- Interviewers: hide clues inside real-sounding interview questions. Job duties, uniform requirements, workplace hazards all work.
- Spread clues across all three components - don't pile everything onto the job and leave the location a mystery.

Facilitator notes

- Interviewers who give clues too subtle or too direct both kill the game - coach them to find the playable middle.
- Host can rescue a stall by nudging the applicant to focus on one component at a time.
- The scene frame is what makes this more than a puzzle - if it collapses into pure clue delivery, the game loses its shape.

Oh Waiter

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice fast joke construction; Practice committing to imperfect ideas quickly.

PLAYERS	TIME	DIFFICULTY	ENERGY
One seated player plus line	5-10 min typical show/practice unit	High	High

Skills: puns / fast stepping forward / concise jokes

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Roles

Player 1

Player 2

Player 3

Player 4

Player 5

Optional host introduction

Our next game is called Oh Waiter. It's for all [number] players. To get us started, may I please have (audience get). [Confirm get.] [Game starts.]

How it works

One player sits in a chair as the restaurant patron. The rest stand in a line.

The audience provides a suggestion. The seated player says: "Oh Waiter! There is a [suggestion] in my soup."

A player steps forward from the line and delivers a joke or pun based on the suggestion.

That player takes the seat; the previous patron returns to the line. Repeat.

Example:

- Patron: "Oh Waiter! There is a piano in my soup."
- Waiter steps forward: "Sorry about that - it must have been a key ingredient."

What success looks like

Players step forward quickly without waiting for the perfect pun; the game keeps a fast, even rhythm; the audience rewards speed and commitment over cleverness.

Participant cues

A bad pun delivered with confidence beats a great pun delivered late. Step forward on "good enough."

Don't undercut yourself after the joke - deliver it and move.

Association paths when you're stuck: sound-alike words, category, famous phrase, object function, literal visual image.

Facilitator notes

The game breaks down when players hang back. Hesitation is the failure mode, not weak puns.

If a small number of players are carrying the game, name it and redistribute.

Strong support players - ones who step forward to protect tempo - are the backbone of this game even if they're not the best pun-makers.

Sit, Stand, Lay

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Force physical awareness during scene work; Encourage players to justify movement and position changes.

PLAYERS Three players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: physical awareness / justification / ensemble adjustment

Setup notes

Materials: Chairs/bench optional; clear floor space

Optional host introduction

Our next game is for three players - and there's one rule. At all times, one player must be sitting, one must be standing, and one must be laying down. The moment anyone changes position, the others adjust. To get us started, may I please have (audience get). [Confirm get.] This is Sit, Stand, Lay.

How it works

Three players perform a scene. At all times: one player must be sitting, one standing, one laying down.

When any player changes position, the others must adjust immediately to restore the required distribution.

Position changes should be justified within the scene - not treated as arbitrary mechanics.

What success looks like

Position changes feel motivated by the scene - emotion, status, environment - not just rule-keeping; the constraint increases energy rather than replacing scene work.

Participant cues

Make every position change a gift to the scene - collapse from grief, stand to assert status, lie down to surrender or hide.

Keep positions visually clear for the audience. Ambiguous postures create confusion.

Don't freeze to avoid disrupting the pattern. Moving is the game.

Facilitator notes

Common failure: players watch the rule so tightly they stop listening emotionally and the scene goes flat.

If one player is driving all movement while others passively react, redirect ownership to the whole ensemble.

Push players to use position changes to affect relationship and stakes - not just to comply with the rule.

Lines from a Box

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Force players to justify unexpected text; Practice incorporation of audience-generated offers.

PLAYERS Usually 2; occasionally 3	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: justification / audience line integration / scene continuity

Setup notes

Materials: Box/hat/bucket; audience-written slips

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Roles

Host

Player 1

Player 2

Player 3

Player 4

Optional host introduction

For our next game, [Player 1] and [Player 2] are going to play a scene - but they're going to pull out lines written by you and deliver them as part of their scene. To get us started, may I please have (audience get). [Confirm get.] This is Lines from a Box.

How it works

- Two to three players perform a scene.
- Before the game begins, audience members write lines of dialogue on slips of paper.
- The slips are placed in a box, hat, bucket, or similar container.
- During the scene, players periodically draw a line from the box.
- The drawn line must be read aloud and incorporated into the scene.
- Players should justify the line as if it naturally belongs in the scene.
- The scene should still be a good scene, not just a sequence of random line readings.
- Players continue until the scene is edited, reaches a button, or the host ends the game.

Participant cues

- The scene must matter before the line matters.
- Players should build a clear who/what/where early so the random lines have something to disrupt.
- Justify the line through:
 - emotional reaction,
 - relationship history,
 - status,
 - confession,
 - misunderstanding,
 - metaphor,
 - memory,
 - threat,
 - secret,
 - or sudden revelation.

- Do not apologize for a strange line.
- Read the line clearly, then immediately make it true.
- The best use of a line often changes the relationship, not just the topic.
- Players should not over-explain every line; a strong emotional commitment can justify more than logic.
- Use the line as fuel, then return to scene work.

Facilitator notes

- Coach players who treat drawn lines as interruptions - the line is an offer to justify, not an obstacle to route around.
 - Watch for scenes that become only about the written lines. The scene should have its own life; the lines feed it.
 - Push players to draw lines at a reasonable pace - too infrequent and the mechanic disappears; too frequent and the scene can't develop.
 - Call out players who laugh at or comment on a line instead of justifying it. Commit and make it true.
 - Coach players to read lines with a clear emotional point of view - delivery matters as much as content.
 - Watch for players who force a literal interpretation when a looser emotional or metaphorical justification would work better.
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Home Shopping Network / HSN

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice guessing out loud under pressure; Practice charades-based support.

PLAYERS Five players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: guessing / charades / producer pacing / salesmanship

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Roles

Producer

Host 1

Host 2

Intern 1

Intern 2

Optional host introduction

Producer: Thank you all for coming to see our live taping of the Home Shopping Network. Producer: (notices the Hosts) Wait, what are you two doing out here - you've got to get to wardrobe and makeup. Go quick. [Hosts leave.] Producer: Now - I need your help stocking the shelves. May I please have (item get). [Confirm get.] Producer: And what makes it special - (unique ability or characteristic get). [Confirm get.] Producer: And who endorses it - (celebrity get). [Confirm get.] [Repeat for products two and three.] Producer: Alright, bring the hosts back in. To help us out - when the hosts guess close, give them snaps. If they get something exactly right, clap. [Hosts return.] Producer: Bad news - teleprompters are down. But your interns have you covered. We go live in three... two... one.

How it works

- Five players participate.
- One player acts as the producer or game introducer.
- Two players are the home shopping hosts.
- Two players are interns who will silently assist the hosts.
- The producer introduces the game and sends the two host players out of the room.
- The producer then gets audience suggestions for three products.
- Each product has:
 - an item,
 - a unique ability or characteristic,
 - a celebrity endorser.
- The host players are called back into the room.
- The producer tells the hosts that the teleprompters are down, but the two interns will help them with their lines.
- The show then goes live with a countdown: "3...2...1."
- The interns play charades to help the hosts guess what they are selling.
- The producer calls "Camera 1" or "Camera 2" to determine which intern is actively giving charades clues.
- The producer may switch cameras to change clue-givers, create rhythm, or rescue a stalled clue path.
- The hosts attempt to identify each item, its unique ability or characteristic, and its celebrity endorser.
- The audience snaps when the hosts are close.
- The audience claps when the hosts correctly guess something.

- If the hosts are stuck, the producer may "go to commercial" and give the hosts a verbal tip.
- The game continues until the hosts identify the required information or the producer ends the game.

Participant cues

- Silence is failure; wrong guesses are part of the game.
- Hosts should guess constantly and broadly:
 - category,
 - size,
 - material,
 - function,
 - setting,
 - emotion,
 - celebrity type,
 - famous roles,
 - rhyming or sound-alike clues.
- Interns should change tactics when a clue does not work.
- Charades should be large, specific, and repeated only when it is clearly helping.
- Hosts should remain cheerful, promotional, and committed to the broadcast even while confused.
- The home shopping frame gives the hosts permission to over-sell partial guesses.
- Audience snaps and claps are part of the information system; players should listen to them.
- The producer should use camera switches actively, not passively.
- Camera switches should help manage rhythm, reset unclear charades, and distribute support between the interns.
- Commercial breaks should be used as rescue tools, not as the main guessing mechanism.
- The producer should give tips that narrow the search without solving the answer for the hosts.
- The best versions keep the energy of a real sales pitch while the hosts slowly discover the truth.
- Interns should separate the clue targets: item, characteristic, and celebrity endorser.
- The producer should choose audience suggestions that are specific and playable, but not impossible.
- The producer needs judgment, not just confidence.
- A strong producer watches four things at once:
 - whether the hosts are still guessing,
 - whether the interns' charades are readable,
 - whether the audience is still engaged,
 - whether the current clue path needs a camera switch or commercial break.
- Weak producers either under-intervene and let the game stall, or over-intervene and rob the hosts of the discovery.
- The best producer keeps the game moving while preserving the illusion that the hosts are figuring it out live.

Facilitator notes

- Coach hosts to stay in character - they are guessing, but they should still try to be hosts.
- Coach hosts who stop guessing and wait for perfect clues - being wrong is fine; silence kills the game.
- Watch for interns who repeat the same unclear charade. Coach them to change tactics: try a different body part of the product, a different user, a different action.
- Coach interns to act out all three elements: the item, the unique characteristic, and the celebrity endorser.
- Encourage hosts to guess broadly first - category before specifics.
- Coach the producer to switch cameras before an intern's clue path fully stalls, not after.

- Coach the producer to call commercial at the right time - too late and the audience has already felt it drag.
 - Watch for the scene frame collapsing. Remind players they are broadcast professionals - keep the show-within-a-show alive.
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Alphabet Game

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice scene work under a verbal constraint; Train players to maintain relationship and situation while tracking an external rule.

PLAYERS Two players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: alphabet tracking / constrained scene work / recovery

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Roles

Player 1

Player 2

Optional host introduction

For our next game, [Player 1] and [Player 2] are going to do a scene - but every time they speak, the first word has to start with the next letter of the alphabet. To get us started, may I please have (a letter from someone's name in the audience). [Confirm get.] This is the Alphabet Game.

How it works

- Two players perform a scene. The audience gives a suggestion used to pick the starting letter.
- Each time a player speaks, their first word must start with the next letter of the alphabet. A player may use multiple sentences in a single turn - only the first word of that turn must carry the letter. Players cycle through the full alphabet back to the starting letter.
- The scene should still be coherent - the alphabet is the constraint, not the content.

What success looks like

Players stay in the scene while tracking the alphabet; lines start cleanly and quickly; difficult letters (Q, X, Z) land without killing the momentum.

Participant cues

- Establish who, what, and where early - the scene needs something to ride on as the constraint tightens.
- A simple, clear line fast beats a clever line slow. Names, commands, and exclamations are fair game.
- Hard letters have go-to openers: "Quick...", "Xavier...", "You...", "Zero chance..." - have them ready.

Facilitator notes

- Players who struggle here are usually splitting their attention between the alphabet and the scene - the goal is to reduce the cognitive load of the alphabet so they can stay present.
- Watch for scenes that flatten to just letter-hunting. Coach players to advance the relationship, not just survive the constraint.
- Missed letters: recover and keep moving unless the format requires correction.

Duets

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice paired verbal coordination; Practice salesmanship and product invention.

PLAYERS Five players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: paired speaking / sales pitch / hosting / rhythm

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Optional host introduction

Shopper: I own a home, and I need (something home-related done or supplied). [Confirm get.] Shopper: I have two of the best (get) companies here competing for my business. Shopper: Company 1, may I have your name. [Name given one word at a time.] Shopper: Company 2, may I have your name. [Name given in unison.] This is Duets.

How it works

- Five players participate.
- One player is the shopper.
- Four players are divided into two pairs.
- Each pair represents a rival company.
- The shopper asks the audience for a product or thing they are shopping for.
- The shopper then asks each duet pair for its company name.
- The shopper asks each duet what makes its product special.
- The shopper asks each duet two to three follow-up questions.
- The duets may occasionally cross-talk or respond to each other.
- One duet pair speaks every other word.
- The other duet pair speaks at the same time.
- The finale is usually the shopper asking each duet for its jingle.
- After hearing the pitches and jingles, the shopper picks a winner.

Participant cues

- The shopper should make the structure easy for the duets.
- Good shopper questions are specific enough to create usable answers:
 - "What makes your version safer?"
 - "Why is your product better for families?"
 - "What happens if I use it incorrectly?"
 - "Who should never buy this?"
 - "What celebrity uses your product?"
- The every-other-word pair should favor simple sentence construction.
- The simultaneous-speaking pair should choose bold obvious answers rather than subtle ones.
- In simultaneous speech, matching energy and direction matters more than exact wording.
- A strong partner in the simultaneous duet can help by physically and vocally committing early, giving the other player something to join.
- Duets should build product identity early so the jingle has something to summarize.

- The shopper should heighten the rivalry without making the duets fight for airtime chaotically.
- The winning choice should feel like a button or payoff, not just an administrative ending.

Facilitator notes

- In the simultaneous-speaking duet, coach for balance: one passive or one aggressive partner breaks the coordination. Both players need to commit equally.
 - Coach the shopper to ask focused questions and balance time between the two companies.
 - Push companies to differentiate themselves - similar pitches make the shopper's choice meaningless.
 - Remind duets they are selling something, not just demonstrating the mechanic.
 - Coach for cross-talk - the pairs are competing.
 - Coach the shopper to actively manage pacing; a passive shopper lets the game stall.
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Master Debater

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice fast verbal justification; Practice committing to absurd arguments.

PLAYERS Judge plus line of debaters	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: rhetorical confidence / objection / justification / tangent control

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Roles

Host / Moderator

Debater 1

Debater 2

Optional host introduction

Judge: Order. Order. Tonight we settle, once and for all, the matter of (audience get - a topic or question worth debating). Counsel, are you prepared? [Players acknowledge.] Judge: Then let's begin.

How it works

- One player serves as the judge.
- The other players stand in a line.
- The judge introduces the game and asks the audience for a topic.
- One player steps forward and begins making a case on the topic.
- At any point, another player in the line may step forward and say, "Objection!"
- The objecting player then objects to something the current speaker just said.
- The objection may be directly related to the topic or may be a tangent inspired by a word, phrase, implication, or detail.
- The judge rules on the objection by saying either:
 - "Sustained," or
 - "Overruled."
- If the objection is overruled, the current speaker continues.
- If the objection is sustained, the objecting player takes over and must continue arguing the point made in the objection.
- The new speaker continues until another player objects.
- The game continues through a series of arguments, objections, rulings, and takeovers until the judge ends the game.

Participant cues

- The speaker should make bold claims quickly.
- The objector should object to something specific, even if the objection is ridiculous.
- A good objection creates a new playable argument, not just a correction.
- The judge should rule fast.
- "Sustained" should usually be used when the objection creates better momentum.
- "Overruled" should be used when the objection is unclear, weak, or would derail a stronger current run.
- The game rewards confidence more than legal accuracy.
- Tangents are useful when they are committed to as if they matter.

- Players should maintain debate energy: formal, passionate, overly certain, and rhetorically inflated.
- The best arguments sound structured even when the logic is absurd.
- Players who are good at setup/punchline construction may thrive if they use that skill to create playable objections rather than simply dropping jokes.
- The ideal move is not just "say a funny objection"; it is "create a funny objection that forces the next argument into a stronger absurd position."

Facilitator notes

- Coach players to object early and often.
 - Objections should have a playable angle.
 - Push objections toward the theatrical and absurd - too logical and the game loses its energy.
 - The judge should rule quickly, sustain objections with playable directions, and overrule ones that don't.
 - Tangents can be good playable arguments.
 - Remind players that a weak objection is still a playable offer - self-consciousness is the bigger failure.
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Spelling Bee

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice fast group coordination; Practice one-word-at-a-time team speaking.

PLAYERS Seven players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: one-word team speaking / character under constraint / host escalation

Setup notes

Materials: Optional bell/host framing; no documented required prop

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Optional host introduction

Pronouncer: Welcome to the (setting) Spelling Bee. Competitors, please introduce yourselves. [Each team introduces themselves one word at a time.] Pronouncer: Our first word is (audience get or host-chosen word - escalate from simple to difficult to invented). [Game begins.]

How it works

One host runs the spelling bee; two teams of three compete. The host establishes a setting (e.g., fourth grade, senior center, prison).

Teams introduce themselves one word at a time.

When asked to spell a word, the team: repeats the word to claps to spells one letter at a time to says the word again to claps.

The host follows up with questions: "Use it in a sentence," "Define it," "Give me the etymology," etc.

Words escalate: simple real words to harder real words to invented or absurd words.

Example:

- Host: "Your word is 'banana.'"
- Team: "Banana. [clap] B-A-N-A-N-A. Banana. [clap]"
- Host: "Use it in a sentence."
- Team (one word at a time): "I / once / ate / a / banana / on / the / moon."

In beginner class, the coach typically serves as host, freeing students to focus on team speaking and character.

What success looks like

Teams go fast and stay in character; correct spelling matters less than confident shared commitment; invented words are defined with total authority.

Participant cues

Speed and character over spelling accuracy. Commit to wrong answers confidently.

Your team introduction establishes a shared identity - make it playable, not generic.

Treat invented words as real. Define them with authority and let the definition reveal character.

Facilitator notes

Hosts: escalate word difficulty gradually. Early words let the audience learn the pattern; later words create pressure and absurdity.

Follow-up questions should heighten character or world - not just be administrative checkboxes.

Common failure: players prioritize correctness over rhythm and the game loses energy. Redirect to confidence and speed.

Breaking News

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice one-word-at-a-time coordination; Practice maintaining a recognizable genre frame.

PLAYERS Two players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: one-word speaking / genre frame / pacing

Optional host introduction

Anchor 1: Breaking. Anchor 2: News. [Newscasters deliver breaking news one word at a time.]

How it works

- Two players perform as newscasters.
- The players deliver breaking news stories one word at a time.
- The stories are usually absurd, heightened, or ridiculous.
- The players maintain the tone and posture of serious newscasters while building the story together.
- The game may move through multiple breaking news stories.
- The players must decide when a story has reached a natural endpoint and when to advance to the next story.
- The game ends when the news sequence reaches a strong final button or when the host/players call the end.
- The game may also appear as an improvised insert inside a long-form set, when players briefly shift into a breaking-news frame to comment on, heighten, or transition from the ongoing long-form material.

Participant cues

- The newscaster genre matters.
- Players should use posture, vocal tone, urgency, seriousness, and broadcast rhythm to sell the frame.
- The comedy often comes from treating absurd events as legitimate breaking news.
- A good story should have a clear enough structure that the audience can follow it:
 - event,
 - who is affected,
 - where it happened,
 - why it matters,
 - absurd escalation,
 - button.
- Players should learn to feel when a story has peaked.
- Moving to the next story is a pacing skill, not an escape hatch.
- Strong transitions can sound like real news pivots:
 - "In other news...",
 - "We now go to...",
 - "Authorities are reporting...",
 - "This just in..."
- The ending should feel deliberate, not like the players ran out of steam.
- The best versions combine fast one-word-at-a-time rhythm with believable newscaster authority.
- As a long-form insert, Breaking News should be used sparingly.
- The player initiating it needs strong judgment; otherwise it can feel like a random genre interruption.

- It works best when it clarifies, heightens, or reframes something already present in the long-form.
- The insert should still preserve the newscaster tone: serious delivery, clean pacing, and a clear button.

Facilitator notes

- Remind players they are newscasters - keep the framing alive.
 - Coach for deliberate broadcast pace.
 - Coach players to recognize when a story has peaked and move on to a new story.
 - Push players to prioritize a clear news-story shape.
 - For younger players who lack newscaster reference points, model the formal, urgent broadcast delivery before the game starts.
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Pillars

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Incorporate audience participation directly into a scene; Practice justifying unexpected words or phrases.

PLAYERS Two players plus two audience volunteers	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: audience care / justification / volunteer support

Setup notes

Materials: Two audience volunteers

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Roles

Director

Actor 1

Actor 2

Pillar 1

Pillar 2

Optional host introduction

For our next game we need two volunteers from the audience. [Two volunteers come onstage. Each stands beside one player.] [Player 1] and [Player 2] are going to play a scene. At any point, they might pause mid-sentence and tap you - and you just say the first word or phrase that comes to mind. [Players demonstrate once with each volunteer.] To get us started, may I please have (audience get). [Confirm get.] This is Pillars.

How it works

Two audience members come onstage - one assigned to each player.

The two players perform a normal scene. At any point a player may pause mid-sentence and tap their assigned volunteer.

The volunteer supplies a word or short phrase. The player immediately incorporates it and continues the scene.

This is a performer-struggle game, not a volunteer-struggle game. The audience member supplies the offer; the improviser carries the responsibility for making it work.

Example:

- Player: "I'm sorry I was late, I had to clean my..." [taps volunteer]
- Volunteer: "Cat."
- Player: "My cat. He was so dirty. Too much catnip."

What success looks like

The volunteer feels safe, funny, and included; inserted words affect the relationship or stakes, not just decorate sentences; the scene stays a real scene.

Participant cues

Set up a clear blank before you tap: "I brought you a..." / "We can't go back to..." - not after you've already finished the sentence.

The volunteer's answer is always right. Your job is to make them look clever, not show how hard the offer was.

Use the inserted word to affect the relationship, not just fill space.

Facilitator notes

Common mistakes: tapping too early (no blank set up), tapping too late (sentence already finished), or using the pillar so often the scene can't develop.

If the volunteer gives a basic or obvious answer, the player still owns the justification - make it work anyway.

The best versions make the audience volunteer feel like they were funny. That's the performer's responsibility, not luck.

3 Chairs

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice large physical character choices; Train players to sustain and inherit characters.

PLAYERS Six players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: character inheritance / observation / big physical choices

Setup notes

Materials: Three chairs; bell

Optional host introduction

For our next game, each of these chairs is going to have a character attached to it - but the player in that chair is going to change. To get us started, may I please have (somewhere people would gather). [Confirm get.] [Three players take the chairs. Three players watch from the side.] This is 3 Chairs.

How it works

- Three chairs are placed on stage.
- Six players participate.
- The audience gives a location where people would gather.
- Three players begin seated in the chairs.
- Each seated player creates a very large physical and character choice.
- The three offstage players watch closely.
- When the offstage players see a button, they ring a bell.
- The seated players exit.
- The three offstage players replace them in the chairs.
- Each incoming player plays the exact same character associated with the chair they take over.
- The characters remain tied to the chairs throughout the game.
- The game continues through multiple rounds.
- The game often continues until players eventually return to their original chairs/characters.

Participant cues

- Big does not mean random.
- The best characters are physically large, vocally clear, and easy for another player to reproduce.
- Players should make choices that are:
 - obvious enough to copy,
 - specific enough to preserve,
 - and playable enough to sustain.
- Offstage players should watch the whole body, not just the voice.
- Incoming players should honor the existing character before adding new heightening.
- A strong replacement performance says: "I understood the offer, and now I am carrying it forward."
- The bell should land on a button, not merely on confusion or impatience.
- Repetition is part of the game; the audience enjoys seeing the same character filtered through different performers.
- The location should continue to matter. It gives the characters something to do besides display quirks.
- The game works best when the inherited characters have clear wants, emotions, and relationships, not just physical abnormalities.

Facilitator notes

- Push for character choices big enough to inherit.
 - Coach incoming players to copy the full body, not just the voice or catchphrase. Watch for surface-level impressions.
 - Watch for character drift over multiple rotations.
 - Coach players to heighten the existing character, not change it.
 - Coach offstage players to edit on a button.
 - Remind players that specific is better than weird.
 - Watch for the location disappearing after the opening.
 - In early practice, establish the inheritance mechanic.
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Foreign Film

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice gibberish performance; Practice translating physical and vocal offers into clear meaning.

PLAYERS Four players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: gibberish / translation / host support / emotional intent

Roles

Host 1 / Translator 1

Host 2 / Translator 2

Player 1

Player 2

Player 3

Player 4

Optional host introduction

[Host 1, in character:] Welcome to (host-invented venue). I'm (fake name that fits the venue) and this is (fake name). [Host 2:] Hi! [Host 1:] Tonight we're bringing you a masterpiece from (host-invented country or region) - but unfortunately there was a mistake in the shipment and our copy arrived without subtitles. So [Player 2] and I will be translating. To get us started, may we please have (audience get - becomes the adjective in the film title). And may we please have (audience get - becomes the noun in the film title). Without further ado, we present: (get one) (get two).

How it works

- Four players participate.
- Two players are the hosts introducing a foreign film.
- Two players are the actors inside the film.
- The hosts ask the audience for a suggestion.
- The hosts use the suggestion to create the title of the foreign film.
- The premise is that the film is in an obscure language, but the subtitles are not working.
- The actors perform a scene speaking gibberish.
- After each gibberish line, the actor pauses.
- One of the hosts translates the line into English.
- The actors continue the scene based on the emotional and physical meaning being created by the translations.
- The game continues until the scene reaches a strong ending or the host/editor ends it.

Participant cues

- Gibberish still needs intention.
- Strong gibberish uses rhythm, volume, pauses, emotional tone, repeated sounds, gesture, eye contact, and physical relationship.
- The host should translate the whole offer, not just the sound.
- Good translations come from what the actor gives: fear becomes confession, pride becomes boast, desperation becomes plea, anger becomes accusation, tenderness becomes vulnerability.
- Hosts should translate quickly enough to preserve rhythm.
- The best translations give the actors a next playable move.
- If an actor gives too little gibberish, the host may still translate from body language, facial expression, or silence.
- The hosts should make the actors look intentional, not expose that they are struggling.
- Leave space between offers: don't talk over your translator. The beat between gibberish and translation is where the game lives.

Facilitator notes

- Actors should deliver enough gibberish to give the hosts something to translate.
 - Actors should commit vocally and physically.
 - Remind actors to pause after each line and let the hosts translate.
 - Coach hosts to follow the actor's physical and emotional offers.
 - Call out translations that contradict the actor's obvious emotional tone.
 - Watch for the scene losing an ongoing narrative.
 - Coach actors to incorporate the host's translation into their next line or behavior.
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Slideshow

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice physical tableau; Practice creating clear stage pictures quickly.

PLAYERS Presenter, listener, 2-3 photo players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: tableau / narration / visual offers / justification

Roles

Presenter (Player 1)

Viewer (Player 2)

Ensemble 1

Ensemble 2

Ensemble 3

Optional host introduction

For our next game, [Player 1] is going to be sharing a slideshow from vacation with [Player 2], and as they do, the other players are going to demonstrate what they're looking at. To get us started, may I please have (audience get - a place you might go on vacation). [Confirm get.] This is Slideshow.

How it works

One player (Presenter) shows vacation photos to another player (Listener). Two or three others create the photos and videos.

The Presenter narrates each image; the Listener reacts, asks questions, and provides stakes.

Photo players freeze strongly for photos; move clearly for videos.

The Presenter may pause, rewind, slow-motion, or freeze-frame a video as needed.

Photo/Video players: Make bold, readable images quickly. Use levels, distance, facial expression. Give the Presenter something interesting to justify.

Presenter: Frame the vacation story. Treat every pose as intentional. Build escalation across photos - location, disaster, relationship turn, consequence.

Listener: React as someone being shown the album. Ask questions. Notice odd details. Provide emotional stakes through surprise, suspicion, or concern.

What success looks like

Each photo adds something new - images are readable from the back of the room; the vacation story escalates; the Presenter treats every pose as a gift.

Participant cues

Photo players: make your image readable before the Presenter speaks. Don't wait for instruction - commit to a bold pose.

Presenter: if a pose is confusing, define it confidently. The physical offer is always right.

Listener: you're not a prop. Your reactions create stakes and give the Presenter somewhere to go.

Facilitator notes

Common failure: vague or unreadable images - push players to use levels, distance, and eye-line.

The vacation story should escalate, not just list unrelated pictures. Coach Presenters to build consequences across photos.

If a video becomes chaotic, the Presenter has tools: pause, rewind, slow-motion, freeze-frame. Teach them to use these.

Gibberish Switch

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice gibberish; Train players to preserve meaning, emotion, and intention across language changes.

PLAYERS Two players plus bell player	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: gibberish / continuity / language switching

Setup notes

Materials: Bell

Optional host introduction

For our next game, [Player 1] and [Player 2] are going to play a scene - but whenever I squeak the pig, they switch languages. English to gibberish, gibberish to English. Mid-sentence if necessary. To get us started, may I please have (audience get). [Confirm get.] This is Gibberish Switch.

How it works

- Two players perform a scene.
- A third player stands offstage or to the side with a bell.
- The scene begins in gibberish.
- Whenever the bell rings, the players immediately switch languages.
- If they were speaking gibberish, they switch to English.
- If they were speaking English, they switch back to gibberish.
- The bell may ring during a sentence, forcing the player to continue the same thought in the new language.
- The scene continues until it reaches a strong ending or the host/editor ends it.

Participant cues

- The strongest version preserves the sentence across the switch.
- If the bell rings mid-sentence, continue the same thought in the new language.
- Gibberish should still have syntax, rhythm, emotional tone, and intention.
- The audience does not need to understand every gibberish word; they need to understand the emotional and relational direction.
- Good gibberish has shape. It should sound like a real language even though it is not one.
- Strong physical choices make the gibberish much easier for the audience to follow.

Facilitator notes

- Coach hosts to initiate a switch regularly.
- Push gibberish to carry real emotional and physical intention.
- Remind players to play the scene, not wait for the switch.

New Choice

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Train players to make fast alternate offers; Break players out of predictable first instincts.

PLAYERS Two players plus caller	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: alternate offers / flexibility / meaningful substitutions

Setup notes

Materials: Caller; no physical prop required

Optional host introduction

For our next game, [Player 1] and [Player 2] are going to perform a scene - but anytime I feel like it I can say "New Choice", and they have to change what they just said. To get us started, may I please have (a get). [Confirm get.] This is New Choice.

How it works

Two players perform a scene. A third player is the caller.

At any point the caller issues a call - the player who just spoke or acted must immediately replace that offer with a new one. The new choice becomes the scene's reality. The caller may call multiple times in a row.

Caller options: "New Choice" (replace the last offer with something meaningfully different) · "New Accent" · "New Reaction" · "New Genre: [genre]" · and other scene-modifying calls. Replacements must be meaningfully different - a new meaning or quality, not a synonym.

Example:

- Original: "I brought you flowers."
- Weak: "I brought you roses." (same meaning)
- Strong: "I brought you divorce papers."
- Stronger: "I brought you the raccoon that ruined our wedding."

What success looks like

Each new choice creates a meaningfully different reality; the caller pushes frequently enough that the game stays alive; players commit instantly without explaining the rejected offer.

Participant cues

Don't give a new word - give a new world. The replacement should change intention, relationship, or stakes.

Treat the newest choice as true immediately. Don't explain or resist the call.

The audience loves watching you abandon safety and discover something better.

On a genre call, the genre changes but the scene doesn't. If you were talking about cars and the genre shifts to Western, you're still talking about cars - swerving to a new topic (suddenly discussing drinks) breaks the game.

- Leave a beat between lines so the caller has room to call - talking over each other buries the calls that make the game work.

Facilitator notes

Under-calling is the most common failure - if the caller isn't calling often, the game disappears into a normal scene.

If the replacement is a synonym, call again immediately. Don't let weak substitutions slide.

Coach callers to push toward bigger emotion, clearer stakes, more specific objects, or stranger relationships - not just different words.

Entrances and Exits

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice listening for cue words; Train justified entrances and exits.

PLAYERS Usually 3 players; can vary	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: cue listening / justified entrances/exits

Optional host introduction

For our next game, we need a little help from you. May I please have a word with multiple meanings? [Confirm get. Assign to Player 1.] [Repeat for Player 2 and Player 3.] Every time a player hears their word, they have to enter or leave the scene. This is Entrances and Exits.

How it works

- Each player is assigned a common word from the audience. Players begin a scene.
- Whenever a player's assigned word is spoken, they must change stage status: enter if offstage, exit if onstage.
- All entrances and exits must be justified within the reality of the scene. Multiple triggers can fire at once.
- Watch out: accidentally saying your own trigger word counts.

What success looks like

Players catch every cue; entrances and exits feel motivated, not mechanical; the scene still has relationship, stakes, and location underneath the constraint.

Participant cues

- Don't just walk on or off - make the movement part of the story. A forced exit can be fear, urgency, embarrassment, or betrayal.
- Stay in the scene even while tracking your word. The constraint is not the whole job.
- A forced entrance should bring energy, information, or pressure - not just presence.

Facilitator notes

- Choose words that are common enough to appear naturally but not so common the scene becomes unplayable.
- Watch for scenes that devolve into players just saying each other's trigger words - coach them to serve the scene, not the mechanic.
- Watch for scenes with no relationship underneath them. Players still have to do a scene, even with the rules.
- Players should justify their entrances and exits.

Number of Words

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice scene work under a verbal constraint; Train players to speak clearly and economically.

PLAYERS Usually 3; sometimes 4	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: word-count constraint / economy / sentence control

Roles

Host
Player 1
Player 2
Player 3

Optional host introduction

For our next game, three players are going to perform a scene - but each of them can only speak a specific number of words per line. I need a number between 1 and 7 for [Player 1]. [Confirm.] One for [Player 2]. [Confirm.] And one for [Player 3]. [Confirm.] Every line must be exactly that many words. If they get it wrong, we'll let them know. To get us started, may I please have (a location). [Confirm get.] This is Number of Words.

How it works

Three players (sometimes four) perform a scene. The audience assigns each player a number between 1 and 7.

Every line each player speaks must contain exactly their assigned number of words. Contractions count as one word.

Incorrect word counts are buzzed. Players are expected to count.

The scene continues until it reaches a strong ending or the host ends it.

Example:

- Player A (1): "Dad."
- Player B (4): "You missed dinner again."
- Player C (7): "I was trapped inside the old carnival."

What success looks like

Players manage the technical constraint without losing the scene - relationship, stakes, and location stay alive; word counts feel deliberate rather than stumbled into.

Participant cues

The word count is the constraint, not the scene - keep playing the relationship.

Fewer words demands stronger words. Load each one with intention.

More words doesn't mean padding - use them to add specificity.

If you miscounted, recover and keep moving. Don't break the scene to correct yourself.

Facilitator notes

The one-word player tends to go passive - coach them to use loaded, active words.

High-count players often pad. Push for specificity over filler.

Common failure: players focus so hard on counting that the scene goes flat. Redirect to the scene first.

Physical action can carry meaning when the verbal constraint is tight.

World's Worst

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice rapid joke generation; Build comfort stepping forward with imperfect ideas.

PLAYERS One host; typically five performers	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY High
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Skills: rapid jokes / character snapshots / brevity

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Roles

Host

Player 1

Player 2

Player 3

Player 4

Player 5

Optional host introduction

This next game is for all [number] players. To get us started, may I please have (an occupation or role - something a person does). [Confirm get.] This is World's Worst.

How it works

- Host gets a suggestion from the audience (profession, role, situation) and announces: "World's worst [suggestion]."
- Players step forward one at a time, deliver a short bit or line demonstrating the world's worst version, then step back. Others continue stepping in.
- Host ends the round when energy dips or a strong button lands, then starts a new round with a fresh suggestion.
- Examples: "World's worst doctor: Good news. I watched half a YouTube video." / "World's worst babysitter: Whoever finds the snake first gets dessert."

What success looks like

Players step forward quickly with confident, brief bits; the pace stays high; jokes land and get out cleanly; the host pulls the ripcord at the right moment.

Participant cues

- Step forward on a good-enough idea. Waiting for the perfect joke kills the game.
- One clear premise delivered confidently beats a long setup every time.
- Get out cleanly after the joke lands. Don't extend it.

Facilitator notes

- Hesitation hurts more than a mediocre line.
- Initiative is important - coach everyone to step forward early and often.
- End each round on a strong laugh or when energy drops - don't let a weak stretch run long.

Survivor

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice scene memory; Practice replaying and preserving a shared scene structure.

PLAYERS 5 scene players plus host	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: memory / replay discipline / role coverage / solo clarity

Setup notes

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Optional host introduction

For our next game, all five players are going to perform a scene together. Pay attention - because after each round, we're going to vote one of them off, and the remaining players have to perform the exact same scene again, covering whoever's missing. To get us started, may I please have (a get). [Confirm get.] This is Survivor.

How it works

Five players perform a scene together. It must establish clear who, what, and where - every player needs at least one memorable contribution.

After each replay, the host removes one player (audience may vote). The remaining players replay the scene from the top, covering the missing player's lines and actions.

The scene resets from the beginning each time. Coverage is flexible - any remaining player may jump in.

When only one player remains, they perform the entire scene solo, covering all characters.

Round 1: 5 players

Round 2: 4 players to cover 1 missing role

Round 3: 3 players to cover 2 missing roles

Round 4: 2 players to cover 3 missing roles

Round 5: 1 player to covers all 5 roles solo

What success looks like

Each replay is recognizably the same scene but increasingly difficult; missing lines are covered without hesitation; the final solo performance is energetic and readable.

Participant cues

In the first scene, give the group something memorable - a distinctive line, action, or physical position worth replaying.

Don't wait for permission to cover a missing line. If no one else is moving, move.

In the final solo, physical and vocal separation between characters is everything - the audience needs to know who you're being.

Facilitator notes

If the original scene is too vague to replay, the whole game falls apart. Coach the first scene to have clear landmarks.

Common failure: remaining players drop missing material rather than covering it. Redirect - preserving the scene's skeleton is the game.

Keep transitions between replays tight. Let the host keep the pace; dragging kills momentum.

Growing and Shrinking

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Practice scene memory; Practice clear scene initiations.

PLAYERS Usually 4-6; FP observed 6	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: scene memory / layered structure / reverse returns

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Roles

Player 1
Player 2
Player 3
Player 4
Player 5
Player 6

Optional host introduction

For our next game, we're going to build a scene one player at a time, and each time a player enters they will start a new scene. Then, one by one, they're going to leave, and the remaining players will return to the scenes they were playing before. To get us started, may I please have a (get). [Confirm get.] This is Growing and Shrinking.

How it works

Growing and Shrinking begins with a true-to-life personal monologue, then grows one player at a time until all players are onstage. It then shrinks back down as players leave in reverse order, returning to earlier scenes.

A simple six-player structure:

- Player A begins alone with a true-to-life monologue - a real, personal story told honestly.
- Player B enters and begins a new scene with Player A.
- Player C enters and begins a completely new scene with Players A and B.
- Player D enters and begins a completely new scene with Players A, B, and C.
- Player E enters and begins a completely new scene with Players A, B, C, and D.
- Player F enters and begins a completely new scene with all six players.

Then the structure reverses:

- Player F exits, and the group returns to the previous five-person scene.
- Player E exits, and the group returns to the previous four-person scene.
- Player D exits, and the group returns to the previous three-person scene.
- Player C exits, and the group returns to the previous two-person scene.
- Player B exits, and Player A returns to the original solo scene or monologue.

Participant cues

- Each scene needs a strong, memorable label in the players' minds.
- Make early scenes simple and specific.
- The first line of each new scene should strongly establish the new reality.
- Use different relationships, locations, body positions, and emotional tones for each layer.
- Physical specificity helps memory.

- When returning to an earlier scene, restart with the strongest remembered offer.
- The shrinking half is the payoff, so the growing half must establish clean, memorable scenes.

Facilitator notes

- Coach players to make their early scenes memorable and distinct.
 - Push for new scenes that are clearly distinct from prior ones in tone, relationship, or energy.
 - Remind players entering that they have to establish the scene for the other players.
 - Watch for the full-stage scene becoming chaotic.
 - Balance the memory load: players who over-focus on remembering stop playing the scene. The goal is both.
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LOW (Location, Occupation, Weapon)

SHORT FORM

Purpose: A guessing/mime game in which detectives are called in one at a time to solve a murder, receiving clues through gibberish and mime - with information mutating through each handoff.

PLAYERS 6 players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium-High
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Skills: gibberish / mime / guessing / clue-giving / memory drift / physical storytelling

Setup notes

Materials: One chair representing a corpse

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Roles

Host

Detective (guesser)

Player 3

Player 4

Player 5

Player 6

How it works

- Six players are selected.
- A chair is placed in the middle of the stage.
- The chair represents a corpse.
- Five of the six players leave the room or otherwise cannot hear the setup.
- The one player who remains receives three pieces of information:
 - the corpse's profession,
 - the location of the murder,
 - the method of murder.
- The audience provides or helps provide these suggestions.
- The player who remains functions as the host / starting detective.
- The three items correspond to the letters L (Location), O (Occupation), and W (Weapon). When miming clues, players sign the letter - L, O, or W - to tell the receiving player which of the three they are currently describing. This keeps the information organized and tells the guesser what category they are receiving.

What success looks like

- The audience can follow the broad intent of the mimed clues.
- The players commit fully to gibberish as meaningful language.
- Each exchange feels like a real detective conversation.
- The information mutates in funny, trackable ways.
- The stage murders are clear and theatrical.
- The final reveal produces escalating comic payoff as the guesses differ from the original setup.
- The game remains fast enough to feel like a show piece rather than a classroom puzzle.

Participant cues

- The game needs bold, readable physical offers.
- Gibberish alone is not enough; the mime must carry the information.

- Players should use the full stage picture, including the chair/corps.
- Incoming players should actively investigate through gibberish questions and physical guesses.
- Clue-givers should respond as if they understand the detective's questions, even though the language is nonsense.
- The scene should feel like a heightened detective investigation, not like silent charades with noise.
- The murder transition should be sudden and clear.
- Wrong guesses are part of the entertainment; players should not overwork the clue transfer until it becomes slow.
- The final reveal should emphasize the drift from the original information through each relay step.

Show Format Note

The game can be run with a Host and 5 players. The Host introduces the game, manages the audience, and interviews the detectives at the end of the scene - asking each detective to recount their version of the murder before revealing what the original setup actually was.

Facilitator notes

- Push clue-givers to be specific and physical.
 - Coach detectives to ask active, physical questions rather than waiting passively. This should feel like a detective conversation, not a guessing game.
 - Remind players not to spend too long seeking perfect certainty.
 - The stage murder transition should be clear and committed.
 - Remind players the relay is a performance, not just a puzzle.
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Luxury / Luxury!

SHORT FORM

Purpose: A four-player complaint and reframing game where players interrupt with "Luxury!" to make the previous problem seem desirable compared to their own worse problem.

PLAYERS 4 players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium-High
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Skills: reframing / escalation / character POV / status contrast / justification / concise ranting

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Optional host introduction

Our next game is for all of our players. May I please have [a get from something annoying]? [Confirm get.] This is Luxury.

How it works

- Host gets a pet peeve or minor complaint from the audience. Player 1 rants about it.
- Another player interrupts with a theatrical "Luxury!" - then explains why Player 1's problem is actually desirable compared to their own worse situation, and begins ranting about that.
- Repeat: each "Luxury!" must reframe the previous complaint as comparatively fortunate, then introduce a new, heightened problem.
- Players keep the characters they establish. Game ends on a strong button.
- Core pattern: "You think that's bad? That would be a luxury compared to my situation..."

What success looks like

Each "Luxury!" gets a laugh by flipping the prior complaint; problems escalate in a clear pattern; players maintain distinct characters; the chain builds to a comic peak.

Participant cues

- The reframe matters as much as the new complaint - justify why the previous problem sounds good before launching into yours.
- Specific misery beats generic misery. The audience needs to understand your problem quickly.
- Keep the character you establish - your complaints should reveal who you are, not just what's bad.

Facilitator notes

- Watch for players who yell "Luxury!" and then skip the reframe - that's where the comic reversal lives.
- New complaints that aren't worse, sharper, or more specific kill the escalation. Coach players to top through specificity, not just extremity.
- The game needs a button - coach the last player or the host to recognize and land the peak rather than letting it trail off.

Complaint Letter / Complaint Letter 3 Words at a Time

SHORT FORM

Purpose: A circle writing exercise where players build a complaint letter three words at a time from a coach-provided complaint topic.

PLAYERS Host + 3 or more players	TIME 3-10 min	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: listening / grammar / group writing / three-word constraint / complaint POV / continuity

Setup notes

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

How it works

- Players stand in a circle or a line. In class the coach gives the group something to complain about; in shows a host takes an audience suggestion for the topic.
- Players take turns contributing exactly three words at a time to build a complaint letter - a "1 star review."
- Each player must listen to the words immediately before their turn and continue the sentence or thought clearly.
- Maintain the complaint-letter tone throughout. The group lands a natural ending; the coach or host may call it.

What success looks like

The letter sounds like one shared complaint; grammar mostly holds; the complaint topic stays clear; the group lands a satisfying final line.

Participant cues

- Listen to the last few words before your turn - serve the sentence first.
- Keep the complaint tone alive; specific complaints are stronger than generic negativity.
- Don't plan ahead. A clear continuation beats a clever derailment.

Facilitator notes

- The three-word constraint gives players more room to derail than one-word-at-a-time - coach them to preserve grammar and direction, not just fill space.
- Watch for: players ignoring the previous words, the letter losing its complaint frame, or over-extending after a natural ending has already arrived.
- Call the ending once the letter lands a satisfying line rather than letting it drag.
- In shows, keep the audience get specific and readable; the host calls the ending.

Key to the City

SHORT FORM

Purpose: A six-player superhero press-conference guessing game where a superhero must infer their name, power, and the disaster they saved the city from through clue-bearing questions and audience snap/clap feedback.

PLAYERS 6 players	TIME 5-10 min typical show/practice unit	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium-High
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Skills: guessing / clue-giving / hosting / reporter characters / audience feedback / press conference framing

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Roles

Press Secretary
Superhero (guesser)
Reporter 1
Reporter 2
Reporter 3
Reporter 4

Optional host introduction

Our next game is called Key to the City. It is a guessing game, so we need our guesser to step outside. [Player exits.] While they're out, may I please have a [get that would make a superhero name]? [Confirm get.] May I please have a disaster that [get] might save the city from? [Confirm get.] May I please have a power that [get] might use to save the city? [Confirm get.] [Recap gets for audience.] OK. Let's bring him back in here. When he comes back, I need your help. If he guesses close, give him snaps. If he is right on, clap. This is Key to the City.

How it works

- Six players are selected.
- One player is the superhero and guesser.
- The superhero leaves the room or otherwise cannot hear the audience suggestions.
- One player remains as the press secretary / presenter.
- The remaining four players are reporters. They embed in the audience before the show begins - seated among the audience members so the opening feels like a real press conference being interrupted by reporters in the room.
- The press secretary gets three audience suggestions:
 - the superhero's name,
 - the superhero's power,
 - the disaster the superhero saved the city from.
- The superhero is called back in.
- The scene is framed as a press conference where the city is honoring the superhero after the disaster.

What success looks like

- The superhero guesses actively throughout the interview.
- Reporters ask clear, funny, clue-bearing questions.
- The press secretary keeps the press conference organized.
- The audience understands the snap/clap feedback system and participates.
- The three target answers are discovered through escalating clues.
- The superhero name, power, and disaster feel theatrically justified by the end.

- The game produces a strong reveal/payoff rather than simply checking off answers.

Participant cues

- The press secretary should explain the audience feedback before the superhero returns or immediately after the return.
- The superhero should keep guessing; wrong guesses are useful.
- Reporters should ask questions that sound like press questions while carrying clues.
- Strong reporter questions reveal both clue information and reporter character.
- The press secretary should track which of the three answers have been solved.
- Once one answer is guessed correctly, shift the clue pressure toward the remaining answers.
- The game works best when the superhero accepts the premise and behaves as if they really are being honored.
- The press conference should feel official enough that the absurdity has a strong frame.
- The audience snapping/clapping gives the guesser a feedback loop, so players should leave space for that feedback to register.

Facilitator notes

- Coach reporters to ask questions that are specific enough to be useful but not so obvious they give the answer away.
 - The press secretary should actively manage order and pacing.
 - Encourage the superhero to guess out loud often.
 - Remind reporters to arrive with their own identity or attitude.
 - Remind players they are reporters, not just question-askers.
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Questions Only

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Players must communicate entirely through questions; any statement or non-responsive question ends your turn.

PLAYERS 4+ players, 2 at a time on stage	TIME 5-10 min	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: active listening / agreement / quick thinking / language precision / scene work

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Optional host introduction

Our next game is called Questions Only. In this game our players can only speak in questions. Any statement - or a question that doesn't respond to the previous question - and you're out. May I please have [a get for a scene location]? [Confirm get.] This is Questions Only.

Setup

Two players take the stage. Remaining players wait on the sides, divided into two groups (left/right). Players self-manage - no host required.

How it works

- Players may only speak in questions. Any statement ends your turn immediately.
- A statement followed by a question is not a valid response. For example, "It's hot in here, are you sweating?" is a violation. (Note: this rule may be refined in future Flying Pig practice as experience accumulates.)
- Each question must respond meaningfully to the previous question. Non-sequitur questions are not allowed. For example, if asked "Would you like a hot dog or a hamburger?" you cannot reply "Who is your favorite singer?"
- You cannot repeat a question already asked in the scene.
- When a player is buzzed out, a new player from the waiting group steps up and a new scene begins.

What success looks like

Players sustain genuine scene work - establishing location, relationship, and stakes - entirely through questions, with the constraint creating pressure rather than collapsing the scene.

Participant cues

- The hardest part is not the question format itself - it's maintaining scene logic while under format pressure. Stay in the scene; the constraint will take care of itself.
- A question that "responds" means you accept what the other player established. You can't just fire off an unrelated question.
- Sentences that start with a question word but trail into a statement are still statements. Monitor your phrasing.

Facilitator notes

- Buzz clearly and without hesitation - ambiguous calls slow the game and reduce the pressure that makes it work.
- The "statement + question" rule (e.g., "It's hot in here, are you sweating?") is the most common gray area. Flying Pig rules treat this as a violation.
- Watch for players who coast by asking vague, scene-neutral questions. The game is more interesting when questions have offers embedded in them.
- New scenes reset each time someone steps up - don't let players try to continue a prior scene.

Thunderdome

SHORT FORM

Purpose: Two team lines face off: the host calls a domain and keeps a rhythm (a squeaky pig, in Flying Pig practice) while active players alternate naming things in the domain on the beat - fall behind, repeat, or miss the domain and you rotate to the back of your line.

PLAYERS Host + 4 or more players (two roughly equal teams)	TIME 3-8 min estimated	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY High
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Skills: quick recall / rhythm / listening / category thinking / performing under pressure / ensemble rotation

Setup notes

Materials: Squeaky toy or other rhythm-keeper (optional)

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

How it works

- A host plus 4+ players in two roughly equal team lines; the front player of each line is active.
- The host calls a domain (Dog Breeds, Countries in Africa, Frozen Foods) and keeps a steady rhythm - observed: squeaking a toy pig.
- The two active players alternate on the beat, naming things in the domain.
- Failure = falling behind the rhythm, repeating an answer, or naming something outside the domain. The failed player goes to the back of their line and the next player steps up.
- In shows the audience chants "Thunderdome! Thunderdome!" at each rotation.
- Time-boxed: the host declares the end; no formal winner.

What success looks like

Answers snap onto the beat; rotations are fast and celebrated; the audience joins the chant unprompted; energy rises as domains get harder.

Participant cues

- An imperfect answer on the beat beats a perfect answer that's late.
- Go to the back of the line cheerfully - the rotation is part of the show.
- Listen: repeats are failures too.

Facilitator notes

- The rhythm is the game; keep it steady and audible.
- Change domains before they run dry.
- In class, the coach hosts; structure is otherwise identical (chant optional).

Long Form

Extended formats built from connected scenes, characters, or themes.

Montage

LONG FORM

Purpose: Generate grounded scene inspiration from truthful personal material; Practice long-form editing.

PLAYERS Usually 5-7; often 6	TIME 15-25 min	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: monologues / thematic listening / editing / two-person scenes

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Roles

Player 1
Player 2
Player 3
Player 4
Player 5
Player 6

Optional host introduction

Now we are going to move into the longform portion of our show. Long Form improv is essentially unscripted theatre. To get us started, may I please have (a get). [Confirm get.] This is Montage.

How it works

Three true monologues open the form: the first inspired by the audience suggestion, the second by the first monologue, the third by the second. After the third, the troupe repeats the original suggestion and claps.

A series of two-person scenes follows, inspired by the monologues' themes, images, emotions, or relationships - not literal reenactments.

Any offstage player may edit. Edits are walk-through edits; new players enter after. Flying Pig prefers longer scenes with deeper relationship development.

Scenes are independent - callbacks are welcome if they arise naturally, but a shared universe is not required.

The monologues are fuel, not scripts. Use them for emotional tone, relationship dynamics, status patterns, fears, desires, specific behaviors - not to reenact what was said.

What success looks like

Scenes feel grounded and specific; edits happen at strong moments; the ensemble supports each other's initiations; the form accumulates meaning without forcing connections.

Participant cues

Start scenes with clear who, what, and where. Vague premises drift.

Edit on a laugh, strong emotional turn, or moment of completion - not just when you feel like entering.

If a scene starts circling the same beat, it's ready to be cut. If it hasn't found its center yet, support it.

Facilitator notes

Monologues that run too long or become too performative drain the opening. Keep them honest and personal.

Common failure: players pull only literal details from monologues. Coach them to reach for theme, emotion, and image instead.

Don't force callbacks or shared-universe connections - the montage doesn't require them, and forcing them makes scenes feel mechanical.

Town Hall

LONG FORM

Purpose: Start a show with immediate audience interaction; Establish characters publicly before scene work begins.

PLAYERS Meeting leader plus planted players	TIME 15-25 min	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: character POV / audience-planted opening / community world-building

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Roles

Moderator

Player 1

Player 2

Player 3

Player 4

Optional host introduction

[Moderator calls the meeting to order.] I'd like to call this meeting to order. We have a number of important issues to discuss today. Before we begin - may I please have (an issue or topic for the community to debate)? [Confirm get.] The floor is now open. Does anyone have something to say about (get)?

How it works

- The form begins as a public meeting, usually framed as an HOA meeting, town hall, or city council meeting.
- One player is not undercover and serves as the meeting leader or facilitator.
- The other players are planted undercover in the audience.
- The meeting leader brings the meeting to order.
- The meeting leader asks the real audience for a suggestion.
- The meeting leader begins calling on the planted players in the audience.
- Each planted player responds in character, giving their take on the issue and introducing themselves.
- Once all player-characters have been introduced, the performers move to the stage.
- The long-form scene sequence begins.
- Scenes are performed in the characters established during the town hall opening.
- Scenes usually begin as two-person scenes.
- Off-scene players may edit scenes when they choose.
- When the form reaches time, a strong culmination, or a natural endpoint, someone calls the end of the game.
- After the long-form ends, someone introduces or transitions into the rest of the show.

What success looks like

Start a show with immediate audience interaction; Establish characters publicly before scene work begins.

Participant cues

- Each planted player should enter with a clear character POV, not just a funny complaint.
- The town hall portion should generate usable scenic material:
 - relationships,
 - grudges,

Facilitator notes

- Undercover players do not commit strongly enough before the reveal.
 - Character introductions become too similar to each other.
 - Players give jokes instead of playable characters.
 - Each planted player should enter with a clear character POV, not just a funny complaint.
 - The town hall portion should generate usable scenic material:
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Repeater

LONG FORM

Purpose: Practice self-editing from inside a scene; Practice transforming a line through character, voice, physicality, and context.

PLAYERS Needs Review	TIME 15-25 min	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: transition / repetition / long-form continuity

Optional host introduction

Our next game is long form. Long form is basically unscripted theatre. To get us started, may I please have (a get). [Confirm get.] This is Repeater.

How it works

Two players perform a scene. At some point, one player repeats the other's last line - as a new character, with a clear change in physicality, voice, or context.

The player whose line was repeated exits. A new player enters and responds to the repeated line as the start of a new scene.

The form continues as a chain of scenes, each launched by a transformed repeated line.

The repeated line must be exact and the character shift unmistakable - otherwise the ensemble can't tell if an edit is happening. Subtle transitions break the form.

What success looks like

The repeated line is recognizable as both a callback and a new scene's first line; exits are clean; entries are immediate; the chain keeps momentum.

Participant cues

Repeat the line as exactly as possible. Changing even a word creates ambiguity about whether you're editing.

Make the character shift unmistakable - physicality, voice, and context should all change.

If you're the player whose line was repeated, trust the edit and leave cleanly. Don't linger.

Facilitator notes

The hardest part: players who need to edit most (stalled scenes) are often least aware they should. Practice self-editing as a skill separately.

Common confusion: players repeat lines during normal dialogue without intending an edit. The character shift is what signals the transition - drill that distinction.

Entering players must respond immediately. Hesitation after a clean edit kills the momentum the technique is meant to create.

La Ronde

LONG FORM

Purpose: Practice linked two-person scenes; Build a long-form structure through character continuity.

PLAYERS Ensemble; sequential two-person scenes	TIME 15-25 min	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: character chain / relationship transitions / continuity

Optional host introduction

Our next game is long form. Long form is basically unscripted theatre. To get us started, may I please have (a get). [Confirm get.] This is La Ronde.

How it works

A chain of two-person scenes. One player always remains as the same character; a new player enters and begins a new scene with them.

In the Flying Pig version, an offstage player tags in for one of the active players - the other stays onstage and continues as the same character.

The form eventually circles back, revealing different sides of each character through different relationships.

Example:

- Scene 1: A + B to C tags out A
- Scene 2: B + C to D tags out B
- Scene 3: C + D to E tags out C
- Scene 4: D + E to ...

What success looks like

The continuing character is clearly recognizable across scenes; each new partner reveals a different side of them; transitions are clean and the chain feels intentional.

Participant cues

If you're the continuing character, preserve who you are - don't shift personality to match the new partner.

If you're entering, establish a new relationship immediately. Don't continue the previous scene's conversation.

Ask yourself: "Who else knows this person, and what different side of them do I bring out?"

Facilitator notes

Most common failure: the remaining player drifts character to match each new partner, and the chain loses its anchor.

Tag-ins should happen on strong moments - not just when a player feels like entering. Early tags cut off scenes before relationships are established.

Distinguish from Repeater: La Ronde edits are triggered from offstage; Repeater edits are triggered from inside the scene by repeating a line.

3 Rooms

LONG FORM

Purpose: Create a braided long-form structure from multiple recurring scene threads; Practice interrupting and returning to scenes.

PLAYERS Ensemble	TIME 15-25 min	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: scene weaving / callbacks / transition discipline / offstage listening / line repetition

Optional host introduction

Our next game is long form. Long form is basically unscripted theatre. To get us started, may I please have (a get). [Confirm get.] This is 3 Rooms.

How it works

Three fixed pairs each own a recurring scene strand. Pair A starts; the others wait offstage.

An offstage pair repeats a line from the active scene - this triggers a different offstage pair to enter. The active pair exits.

Pairs do not trigger their own scene. Pair C repeating a line triggers Pair B, not Pair C.

When a pair returns, they resume their own strand and justify the repeated line in their own context. Time jumps are common.

Example cycle:

- Pair A active to Pair C repeats a line to Pair B enters, Pair A exits
- Pair B active to Pair A or C repeats a line to Pair C enters, Pair B exits
- Pair C active to cycle continues...

What success looks like

The audience can track all three strands; repeated lines feel satisfying and then surprising when justified in a new context; each return advances the scene rather than replaying it.

Participant cues

Listen from offstage. You need a line worth repeating before you can trigger anything.

When you return to your strand, don't just resume - something should have changed: time, status, stakes, consequence.

The repeated line isn't just a cue - justify it so it becomes true in your scene.

Facilitator notes

- Drill the rule early: you trigger others, not yourself. This is the most common point of confusion.
- Coach each return to escalate or reveal something new.
- Push pairs to establish distinct identities from the start.

Slacker

LONG FORM

Purpose: Build a long-form set through connected two-person scenes; Practice preserving one character while revealing them through new relationships.

PLAYERS Ensemble	TIME 15-25 min	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: tag-outs / character chain / dependency on repeated line/name

Optional host introduction

Our next game is long form. Long form is basically unscripted theatre. To get us started, may I please have [a get]. [Confirm get.] This is Slacker.

How it works

Two players begin a scene. An offstage player physically tags out one of them - that player exits.

The entering player starts a new scene with the character who stayed, establishing a new relationship immediately. Time jumps are common.

The form follows the character who stayed - each new scene reveals a different side of them through a new relationship.

The entering player doesn't have to be someone mentioned in the previous scene - they invent a new relationship with whoever remains.

Example chain: Dentist & patient to patient stays, wedding planner enters (patient is now a photographer) to photographer stays, bride enters to bride stays, bride's sister enters...

What success looks like

Each tag-out is clear; the audience knows who stayed; the new relationship is established fast; the staying character remains recognizable while each scene reveals something new.

Participant cues

If you're entering, name or imply the relationship right away: "Dad..." / "Officer..." / "Professor, the committee rejected your theory."

If you're the staying character, preserve who you are - let the new relationship reveal a different side, not a different person.

Use time jumps to create development: later that day, years later, after the relationship changed.

Facilitator notes

Most common failure: the staying player drifts character to match the new partner, and the chain loses its anchor.

Entering players who wait for the staying character to define the relationship stall the scene. The entering player owns the initiation.

The chain should evolve through relationships and emotional reveals - not just mechanical tagging from one scene to the next.

Two Chairs

LONG FORM

Purpose: Practice building scenes from physical stage pictures; Train players to justify unusual object configurations immediately.

PLAYERS 4+ players	TIME 15-25 min	DIFFICULTY Mid-High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: object transformation / stage picture / two-player scene initiation

Setup notes

Materials: Two chairs

Roles

Player 1

Player 2

Optional host introduction

Our next game is longform. Longform is essentially unscripted theatre. To get their scenes started the players are going to react to the chairs on stage. This is Two Chairs.

How it works

- 4 or more players participate.
- Two chairs are placed on stage in an unusual configuration by two players from the group.
- The configuration may include chairs being upside down, tilted, sideways, stacked or partially stacked, facing odd directions, separated at strange distances, or otherwise arranged in a way that suggests an object, location, obstacle, creature, vehicle, machine, or piece of environment.
- Two different players then begin a two-person scene inspired by the configuration.
- On a button, the two active players make eye contact, exit the scene, and move the chairs into a new configuration for the next pair.
- Any two players from the waiting group may jump in for the next scene - there is no fixed rotation.
- The game continues until the players (or teacher in class) call the end. Players are generally aware of the clock.

What success looks like

- Each chair arrangement inspires a distinct scene.
- The audience can clearly understand what the chairs have become.
- Players physically use the chairs in a committed, readable way.
- The new realities are surprising but coherent.
- Scenes feel emotionally grounded even when the object interpretation is strange.
- Edits feel clean because the outgoing players create a strong visual offer for the next scene.
- The form has variety, momentum, and strong visual play.

Participant cues

- The props are always chairs, but you can treat them as anything - a spaceship, a monster, a doorway, a weapon.
- They can also just be chairs. A mix of literal and transformed interpretations across the set makes for a stronger game.

Facilitator notes

- Coach players who ignore the chair configuration entirely - the configuration is the initiation; a generic scene that ignores it is a missed offer.
- Coach players who identify what the chairs are but don't physically interact with them - commitment means using the object, not just naming it.

- Watch for scenes that are too similar to previous ones in how the chairs are interpreted. Encourage range across the set.

Scramble

LONG FORM

Purpose: Overlapping longform format using solo starts, stacked scenes, bolts, swinging gates, and chair pimps; players embrace chaos and commit fully to whatever scene they are currently in.

PLAYERS 6 observed	TIME 15-25 min	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY High
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Skills: longform structure / ensemble awareness / solo initiation / emotional and physical commitment / working with invisible characters / scene overlap / stage picture / editing through initiation / comfort with ambiguity

Setup notes

Materials: Chairs optional

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Working-note flag: documentation for this activity is incomplete. Confirm the structure before teaching it.

Optional host introduction

Our next game is longform. Longform is essentially unscripted theatre. To get us started, may I please have [a get]. [Confirm get.] This is Scramble.

How it works

Begins with a solo start - one player alone, making a bold physical/emotional choice, interacting with an invisible character.

Players initiate new scenes on top of existing ones (overlap edits), creating stacked simultaneous scenes.

Scenes benefit from distinct contrast in energy, tone, or tempo so the audience can separate the threads.

Core techniques:

- Solo Starts: one player alone; interact with an invisible character as if real
- Overlap Edits: initiate a new scene on top of an existing one - previous scene doesn't end
- Stacked Scenes: multiple scenes active simultaneously; may share the same physical space
- Bolts: decisively leave a scene; your character stays behind for the remaining player(s)
- Swinging Gates: use bolts to move between scenes; commit fully to whichever scene you're in
- Chair Pimps: plant a chair as a scenic offer for later scenes to use

Note: Flying Pig-specific rules for this form still need validation (reviewed 2026-07-06 - kept as needs-review pending re-observation).

What success looks like

The stage feels alive and chaotic but not randomly broken; players stay emotionally committed; the audience can absorb contrasting threads; bolts and gates create fluid movement.

Participant cues

Embrace confusion - don't try to understand everything happening. Commit to the scene you're in right now.

Invisible characters must be treated as real. Leave space for their lines; react to them.

In stacked scenes, contrast is how the audience tells threads apart. Different tempo, volume, or emotion makes coexistence readable.

Facilitator notes

The form requires strong commitment, not casual randomness. Chaos without emotional investment is just noise.

Bolts must be decisive. A vague exit doesn't leave the character behind - it just looks like the player wandered off.

Common failure: all stacked scenes have the same energy, and the audience can't separate them. Coach for contrast.

French Braid

LONG FORM

Purpose: A long-form structure where multiple scene strands are created, interrupted, and returned to later, allowing callbacks, continuation, and braided scene development.

PLAYERS 4-8 players	TIME 15-25 min	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: long-form memory / callbacks / scene continuation / editing / re-entry timing / structural awareness

Working-note flag: documentation for this activity is incomplete. Confirm the structure before teaching it.

Roles

Player 1
Player 2
Player 3
Player 4
Player 5
Player 6

Optional host introduction

Our next game is longform. Longform is essentially unscripted theatre. To get us started, may I please have [a get]. [Confirm get.] This is French Braid.

How it works

Multiple scene strands are created through interruptions and transitions.

Earlier scenes return later and continue from where they left off - they don't restart.

The form braids between recurring threads rather than treating each scene as an unrelated montage.

Flying Pig plays it with three strands (Troy-confirmed 2026-07-06). Transition mechanics, opening, and ending still need confirmation.

Returning scenes bring new information, callbacks, heightened relationships, or consequences.

What success looks like

The audience recognizes returning scenes; earlier offers matter later; strands evolve rather than repeat; the form feels intentionally woven.

Participant cues

Returning scenes should continue, not reset. Pick up with consequence, escalation, or changed emotion.

Each strand needs enough clarity in its first appearance to be recognizable when it returns.

The structure rewards patience and listening - resist interrupting before the current scene has produced usable material.

Facilitator notes

Common failure: returned scenes restart instead of continuing, and the form collapses into montage.

Scene threads need to be distinct enough to track - if strands are too similar, the braid is invisible.

Strong returns bring payoff: consequence, callback, or emotional shift from what was established before.

Closers

High-energy structures suited to ending a class, workshop, or show.

Five Things

CLOSER

Purpose: First-instinct thinking; Confidence.

PLAYERS Circle / one active at a time	TIME 5-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY High
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Skills: fast association / confidence / supportive failure

How it works

- One player receives a prompt or category.
- The player rapidly lists five examples.
- The examples may be true, false, absurd, or only loosely connected.
- Fast is more important than accurate.
- After completing the list, that player creates a new prompt for the next player.
- Players usually stand in a circle.
- The next player is usually someone who has not gone yet.
- In practice, players often pick someone across the circle, but the functional rule is to choose someone who has not gone.

What success looks like

First-instinct thinking; Confidence.

Participant cues

- Momentum matters more than truth.
- The audience/group support should make the player feel like succeeding is inevitable.
- The player should not apologize for weak answers.
- The prompt-giver should not use the game to trap another player.

Facilitator notes

- The main failure mode is hesitation - coach players to keep moving even if the next answer is weak. Momentum matters more than quality.
- Watch for players searching for the perfect answer or freezing near the end of the list. Redirect: any answer is better than a pause.
- The audience/group support should make the player feel like succeeding is inevitable.

Name Game

CLOSER

Purpose: Learn names; Build physical commitment.

PLAYERS Circle / whole group	TIME 5-10 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY High
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Skills: name recall / group cohesion / physical offers

Setup notes

Materials: Music/audio, usually Uptown Funk

How it works

One player states their name and performs a physical motion. The whole group repeats the name and mirrors the motion back. Continue around the circle until every player has introduced themselves. Optionally follow with a "ripple" pass: point to any player, the group names them and does their motion together.

What success looks like

Every player's name can be recalled by the group without hesitation; motions are mirrored with commitment and warmth; the room feels connected and supportive rather than pressurized.

Participant cues

- Make the motion big enough to read and simple enough to repeat.
- The goal is not dance skill; the goal is commitment and group memory.
- The group should support imperfect recall rather than making mistakes feel costly.
- The exercise works best when the room treats each motion as a gift.

Facilitator notes

- Watch for self-consciousness - it's the main blocker. Model commitment and normalize imperfection early.
- Coach players whose actions are too small or too complex to repeat. The motion needs to be big enough to read and simple enough for the group to reproduce.
- The goal is not dance skill; the goal is commitment and group memory.

Conducted Song / Show-Closing Conducted Song

SHOW RITUAL

Purpose: End a show by recycling memorable lines from earlier scenes; Create a musical or rhythmic callback to the whole performance.

PLAYERS Host/conductor plus line of players	TIME 1-5 min	DIFFICULTY High	ENERGY High
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Skills: musical rhythm / conductor control / show closer energy

Setup notes

Materials: Possible accompaniment not documented; conductor/host required

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

Roles

Conductor

Player 1

Player 2

Player 3

Player 4

Player 5

Optional host introduction

Thank you all for coming tonight. We've got one more game for you. [Conductor takes position. Game begins.]

How it works

- One player serves as the conductor.
- The conductor is usually the person ending the show.
- The conductor was also a performer in the show earlier; they are not an outside musical director.
- The other players stand in a line facing the audience.
- The conductor stands in front of the line and faces the players.

What success looks like

- The audience recognizes lines from earlier in the show.
- The repeated lines become funny or satisfying in combination.
- The group finds a shared rhythm.
- The conductor shapes the piece clearly.
- Musical players add texture without making non-singers look bad.
- The closer feels like a final callback to the whole show.
- The group ends together on a clean cutoff.

Participant cues

- Choose short, repeatable lines.
- The line does not have to be witty by itself; silliness out of context is often enough.
- Repetition creates the game.
- The conductor should be bold and clear, even without formal conducting skills.

Facilitator notes

- Coach players to choose short, memorable lines.

- Encourage players to listen and claim something distinct.
 - Remind players the line doesn't need to be witty - silliness out of context is often enough.
-

Show Craft

Practical notes for suggestions, openings, closings, and audience care.

The Get (Getting a Suggestion)

SHOW CRAFT

Purpose: How to ask an audience for a suggestion - wording, technique, and how to use what you receive.

PLAYERS 1 (the player soliciting the suggestion)	TIME Under 1 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Low
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Skills: audience connection / suggestion interpretation / offer framing

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

The Flying Pig Wording

At Flying Pig, a suggestion is always solicited with: **"May I please have (a / something) ..."**

This phrasing is a house convention. Variations like "Can I have...", "Give me...", or "Tell me..." are incorrect and will be corrected in class.

Good Examples

- "May I please have something that fits into a box this big." (*mime the size*)
- "May I please have a word with multiple meanings."
- "May I please have a non-geographical location, like a bathroom or a studio."

Bad Examples

- "Give me something small."
- "Can I have a word with multiple meanings."
- "Tell me a location that isn't geographical, like a bathroom or a studio."

Constraint and Creativity

How specific you make the ask shapes what you get back.

- A *constrained* ask ("May I please have a job that starts with the letter P") is more likely to produce common, predictable answers - Plumber, Painter, Pilot.
- An *open* ask ("May I please have a type of job") is more likely to produce unexpected answers - Paleontologist, Puppeteer, Patent Attorney.

Use constraint deliberately: if the game needs a mundane, workable suggestion, constrain more. If the game benefits from a surprising or unusual one, constrain less.

Interpreting the Get (A to C)

Don't use the suggestion literally. Take it from A to C.

If the suggestion is *Diamonds*, don't do a scene about diamonds. Instead, go to something the suggestion *invokes* - jewelry broadly, smuggling, mining, wealth, pressure, engagement, DeBeers marketing. The suggestion is a launching point, not a script note.

This is especially important in longform, where using the get too literally produces a narrow or on-the-nose scene. Shortform games may use the get more directly depending on format.

(A-to-C framing attributed to Sharla.)

Participant cues

- Memorize the "May I please have" phrasing - it is a house convention, not a suggestion.
- When asking for something specific, less constraint usually produces more interesting material.
- When you receive the suggestion, your first instinct (A) is often what everyone else would think of. Go one step further (C).

Facilitator notes

- Correct "Can I have" and "Give me" immediately and consistently - the phrasing carries the relationship with the audience.
 - The A-to-C principle is especially worth reinforcing before longform sets, where lazy gets produce flat openers.
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Show Opener

SHOW CRAFT

Purpose: The structured opening sequence that welcomes the audience, explains improv, covers safety, trains the audience, and brings the troupe on stage.

PLAYERS 1 host plus full troupe	TIME 3-5 min	DIFFICULTY Mid	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: audience connection / host presence / show structure

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

1. Thank the audience

> "Thank you for coming to Flying Pig Improv."

2. Explain what improv is

> "The show you see tonight will be completely unique - there will never be another one like it - because we do improv. That means we don't work with scripts; we make everything up on the spot. We do shortform games, which you might be familiar with from *Who's Line Is It Anyway?*, and we also do longform, which is basically unscripted theatre."

3. Safety

> "The main door to the theatre is the one you came in. If for some reason that exit is blocked, there is a second exit from the back of the greenroom - but that door leads directly out onto Douglas, so be careful if you have to exit that way."

4. Train the audience

> "We don't have microphones, so if you're having trouble hearing us, just hold up two fingers in a V and we will speak louder."

> "We're going to ask you to help us from time to time. To give you a sense of how that goes - can anyone tell me what they had for breakfast this morning?"

(If a guessing game is in the show:)

> "We also have a guessing game tonight. If the player guesses close, please snap your fingers. If they guess right, give them some claps."

5. Summon the troupe

> "We are ready to go. The last thing we need to do is summon our troupe - and I need your help with that. On the count of three, please yell '[troupe name], get in here!' One. Two. Three."

6. Troupe introduction

Troupe enters and introduces themselves by first name, stage left to stage right.

For Hosts

- The audience training section is functional, not decorative - it establishes participation norms before the first game begins.
- The breakfast question is a low-stakes warm-up that shows the audience what giving a suggestion feels like and confirms they're willing to participate.
- The guessing game instructions are conditional - include them only if that format is in the show.
- The troupe summon is a ritual moment; commit to it fully and hold the energy through the intro.
- Keep the opener moving - it should feel welcoming but not stall before the first scene.

Show Closing

SHOW CRAFT

Purpose: The structured closing sequence that thanks the audience, promotes upcoming shows and classes, and sends the troupe off stage.

PLAYERS 1 host plus full troupe	TIME 2-4 min	DIFFICULTY Low	ENERGY Medium
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Skills: audience connection / host presence / show structure

Setup notes

Audience: An audience suggestion or participation is used.

Host: A host or facilitator has an active role.

1. Thank the audience

> "Thank you so much for coming to see us. If you enjoyed it, please leave us a review."

2. Invite to upcoming Flying Pig events

Shows:

> "We do a new show every Friday and Saturday night. Every show is unique, so come and see them."

Sketch Comedy:

> "At the end of the month, we have a sketch comedy group that performs here after our show."

Classes:

> "If this looks like something you'd like to try, we run classes."

- Drop-in Shortform class: every Saturday at 11 AM
- Silver Improv (55+): every Tuesday at 11 AM
- Advanced class (short and longform): Thursday evenings

3. Troupe farewell

Troupe introduces themselves by first name, stage left to stage right, then exits.

For Hosts

- The review ask is brief but worth delivering clearly - it's one of the most valuable things an audience member can do for the theatre.
- The class pitch is a genuine invitation, not just housekeeping. Deliver it like you mean it.
- Class times are current as of documentation but may change - verify before each show.
- The troupe introduction mirrors the opener; it bookends the show and gives the audience a final moment with each performer by name.

History of Improv / Viola Spolin

SHOW CRAFT

Purpose: The origin of theater games and modern improv - Viola Spolin, her settlement house work, Paul Sills, and the lineage to Second City.

PLAYERS N/A	TIME N/A	DIFFICULTY N/A	ENERGY N/A
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Skills: improv history / context

Context

This is not a game or exercise - it is background on where improv comes from. Jesse references this history in class.

Jesse's Version (as told in class)

"I'll bet you think these feel a bit like children's games. Well, actually they were initially invented by a woman named Viola Spolin, who created them to help neurodivergent children and ESL children communicate better. To this day her kids are running Spolin workshops."

The Historical Record

Viola Spolin (1906-1994) was born in Chicago to Russian Jewish immigrants. In the late 1930s and early 1940s, she worked as a drama supervisor for the WPA's Recreational Project, developing games for use with immigrant and inner-city children in settlement houses. Her key insight: lectures about theater technique were useless with children or adults who had limited English, but when those techniques became the focus of a *game*, students could absorb them organically. She was influenced by Neva Boyd, whose work at Chicago's Group Work School explored using traditional game structures to break down cultural and ethnic barriers.

Her games were designed to reach across divisions of culture and language - the "ESL children" framing Jesse uses is essentially accurate, though "ESL" is modern terminology for what Spolin was observing in the 1930s.

The "neurodivergent children" framing does not appear explicitly in the historical record, though the exercises were demonstrably useful in therapeutic contexts for children with learning differences. (See Troy's commentary.)

In 1955, Spolin taught her games to actors working with her son, **Paul Sills**, at the University of Chicago. Sills used them with the **Compass Players** - the first improvisational theater in America - whose cast included Mike Nichols, Elaine May, and Alan Alda. Sills went on to co-found **The Second City** in Chicago in 1959.

In 1963, Spolin published *Improvisation for the Theater*, which compiled her theater games. It remains the foundational text of the form.

"Her kids are running Spolin workshops"

Jesse's reference to "her kids" points to Paul Sills (1927-2008), who was her son and the primary carrier of her work into the American improv tradition. Sills died in 2008. The Spolin estate and website (violaspolin.org) continue to maintain and promote her work and theater games.

Why It Matters

The games used at Flying Pig - including warmups, exercises, and shortform formats - are part of a continuous lineage from Spolin's settlement house work. They were never designed primarily as entertainment; they were tools for human connection across barriers. That origin is still visible in how they function.